



CITY: Pg 3

Delhi pumps ₹1K cr into Yamuna revival



NATION: Pg 5

Cong won't rest till Pradhan resigns: Rahul on NEET paper leak issue



FILM: Pg 12

'Bollywood no longer sets trends'

ENERGY, VISAS, TRADE DOMINATE INDIA-US TALKS

India, US look to turn a new page as Jaishankar and Rubio hold talks

Jaishankar raises visa issues with Rubio; he says 'not targeted at India'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India and the United States moved to repair a relationship that had gone through a rough patch, as External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar and US Secretary of State Marco Rubio sat down Sunday for wide-ranging talks covering trade, visas, energy, terrorism and the ongoing conflict in West Asia.

When Jaishankar raised the concerns about changes to US visa and immigration policy under the Trump administration, Rubio said the changes were not aimed at India specifically but were being applied globally, and that the end result would be a more efficient system for everyone. Jaishankar made the case that legal mobility between the two countries should not take a hit from the broader reform drive.

Rubio acknowledged the concern without dismissing it. "Anytime you undertake a reform, any time you undertake a change in the system by which you admit people, there's going to be a period of transition that's going to create some friction points and some difficulties," he said.

Rubio, visiting India for



External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar during a meeting with US Secretary of State Marco Rubio, in New Delhi

KEY POINTS

- » Rubio called India "one of our most important strategic partners in the world"
- » He said the US-India relationship has not lost momentum
- » Jaishankar laid out a five-point framework guiding India's global approach
- » India opposes weaponisation of market access and backs safe maritime commerce
- » West Asia crisis and Hormuz tensions were flagged as energy security concerns
- » India has seen a significant uptick in energy imports from the US
- » Jaishankar raised concerns about Trump administration's visa and immigration changes
- » Rubio said reforms are not targeted at India and apply globally

'India can count on me, Modi a friend': Trump joins Delhi event via call

NEW DELHI: US President Donald Trump on Sunday sent a strong message of support to India and Prime Minister Narendra Modi during a virtual appearance at the 250th US Independence Day celebrations hosted at the US Embassy in New Delhi, saying India could count on him "100 per cent".

Speaking live during the event, Trump described Modi as a close friend and spoke warmly about ties between the two countries, which have been expanding across trade, defence and the Quad partnership.

"I love India," Trump said. "I love the Prime Minister. PM Modi is great, he is my friend." He added, **Continued on P4**

conference. The two countries had seen a notable dip in relations after Washington **Continued on P4**

US, Iran inch closer to peace deal; Trump says not to rush

Strait would reopen and Iran may surrender enriched uranium, would be able to sell oil

ASSOCIATED PRESS

CAIRO: The United States and Iran appear to be edging closer to a deal that could end months of conflict, reopen the strategically vital Strait of Hormuz and curb Tehran's nuclear programme, with US President Donald Trump and Secretary of State Marco Rubio saying significant progress has been made, though key details including the fate of Iran's highly enriched uranium remain under negotiation.

Iran has not publicly committed to giving up its uranium — a key demand of Trump — and the sides previously seemed close to a deal in recent weeks. Trump on Saturday said a deal had been "largely negotiated," after calls with Israel and other regional allies.

"The negotiations are proceeding in an orderly and constructive manner, and I have informed my representatives not to rush into a deal in that time is on our side," Trump said on social media Sunday. He said the US relationship with Iran is becoming "much more professional and productive."

The strait's reopening would begin to ease a worldwide energy crisis sparked by



FILE PHOTO

KEY POINTS

- » Trump said the agreement has been "largely negotiated", while Secretary of State Marco Rubio said "significant progress" has been made, though talks are not final
- » A central sticking point remains Iran's stockpile of highly enriched uranium, with Tehran yet to publicly commit to surrendering it

the surprise US and Israeli bombardment of Iran on Feb. 28, which led Tehran to effectively close the crucial waterway. Prices have spiked for oil, gas and several downstream products, jolting the world economy. Experts say it would take several weeks or even months for shipping and prices to recover to pre-war levels.

The US has blockaded Iranian ports for over a month,

and Trump on Sunday said the blockade "will remain in full force and effect until an agreement is reached, certified, and signed."

Secretary of State Marco Rubio, on a visit to India, said that "significant progress, although not final progress, has been made" in negotiations, and the world would no longer need to fear Iran getting a nuclear weapon, without elaborating. **Continued on P4**

BJP sweeps Bengal's Faltā Assembly re-poll by over one lakh votes

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: Following the BJP's emphatic victory in the Faltā assembly repoll on Sunday, Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari launched a blistering attack on the Trinamool Congress, claiming the once-celebrated "Diamond Harbour model" had now turned into a "Trinamool har-bar model" (losing model).

Thanking voters for handing the BJP what he described as an "overwhelming mandate", Adhikari said the people of Faltā had "restored democracy" by voting freely after years of alleged political intimidation. **Continued on P4**

Karnataka: 10 drown while collecting mussels in river

MPOST BUREAU

KARWAR (KARNATAKA): At least 10 members of a family, including seven women, died and two others remained missing after they were swept away by strong currents in the Tatte Hakkalu river in Karnataka's Uttara Kannada district on Sunday while collecting freshwater mussels, police said.

The incident took place near Shirali village in Bhatkal taluk, where around 14 people had entered the river as part of a seasonal livelihood activity practised by some local communities. According to police sources, the group moved into deeper waters without fully assessing the water level when the current suddenly intensified **Continued on P4**

UP'S BANDA NEARS 47 DEGREES CELSIUS

Heatwave conditions to persist across India till May-end: IMD

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Large parts of India remained under intense heat on Sunday, with Uttar Pradesh's Banda once again recording the highest temperature in the country at 46.8 degrees Celsius, according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), as weather officials warned that harsh conditions are likely to continue for several more days.

The IMD said heatwave to severe heatwave conditions are expected across central and northwest India over the next seven days, while eastern and adjoining peninsular regions are likely to face sim-



People walk amid heatwave conditions on a summer day, in Varanasi, Sunday

ilar conditions for the next three to five days. However, the weather office indicated that gradual relief may begin from May 29. **Continued on P4**

GOVT TO CRACK DOWN ON ILLEGAL IMMIGRANTS

Bengal orders 'holding centres' for B'deshis, Rohingyas in all districts

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The order was issued from Nabanna following recent statements by Suwendu Adhikari regarding strict enforcement of central guidelines on illegal immigration
- » According to the directive, the centres will house newly detained suspected infiltrators as well as foreign nationals released from prisons whose deportation process is underway
- » Instructions regarding the holding centres have been sent to the Director General of Police, district magistrates, superintendents of police and all police commissioners, including those in Kolkata



FILE PHOTO/ ANI

- » The move follows an eight-page advisory issued on May 2, 2025, by the Foreigners Division of the Union Home Ministry concerning Bangladeshi and Rohingya immigrants
- » The advisory allows law enforcement agencies to detain persons suspected of not being Indian citizens and keep them in holding centres for up to 30 days while their documents are verified.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: The West Bengal government has directed all districts to set up "holding centres" to detain suspected Bangladeshi nationals and Rohingya immigrants for up to 30 days pending verification of their citizenship and deportation status.

The order, issued by Nabanna, follows recent announcements by Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari that the state would strictly enforce the Centre's guidelines on illegal

immigration.

According to the state government's directive, the centres will house not only newly detained suspected infiltrators but also foreign nationals released from prisons whose deportation process is underway. Instructions have been sent to the Director General of Police, district magistrates, superintendents of police and all police commissioners, including Kolkata.

The move comes in line with an eight-page advisory **Continued on P4**

Feared Manipur-like crisis in Ladakh, talks bring hope: Wangchuk

NEW DELHI: Activist Sonam Wangchuk has described the latest talks between Ladakh representatives and the Centre as a positive development, while saying trust in the region will depend on concrete action in the coming weeks.

Speaking to PTI on Saturday after the latest round of discussions with a Ministry of Home Affairs sub-committee, Wangchuk said the Thursday meeting had changed his outlook to some extent, though he remained guarded.

"This meeting has made some difference... Otherwise, I was very disappointed," he said, referring to his earlier detention this year. **Continued on P4**



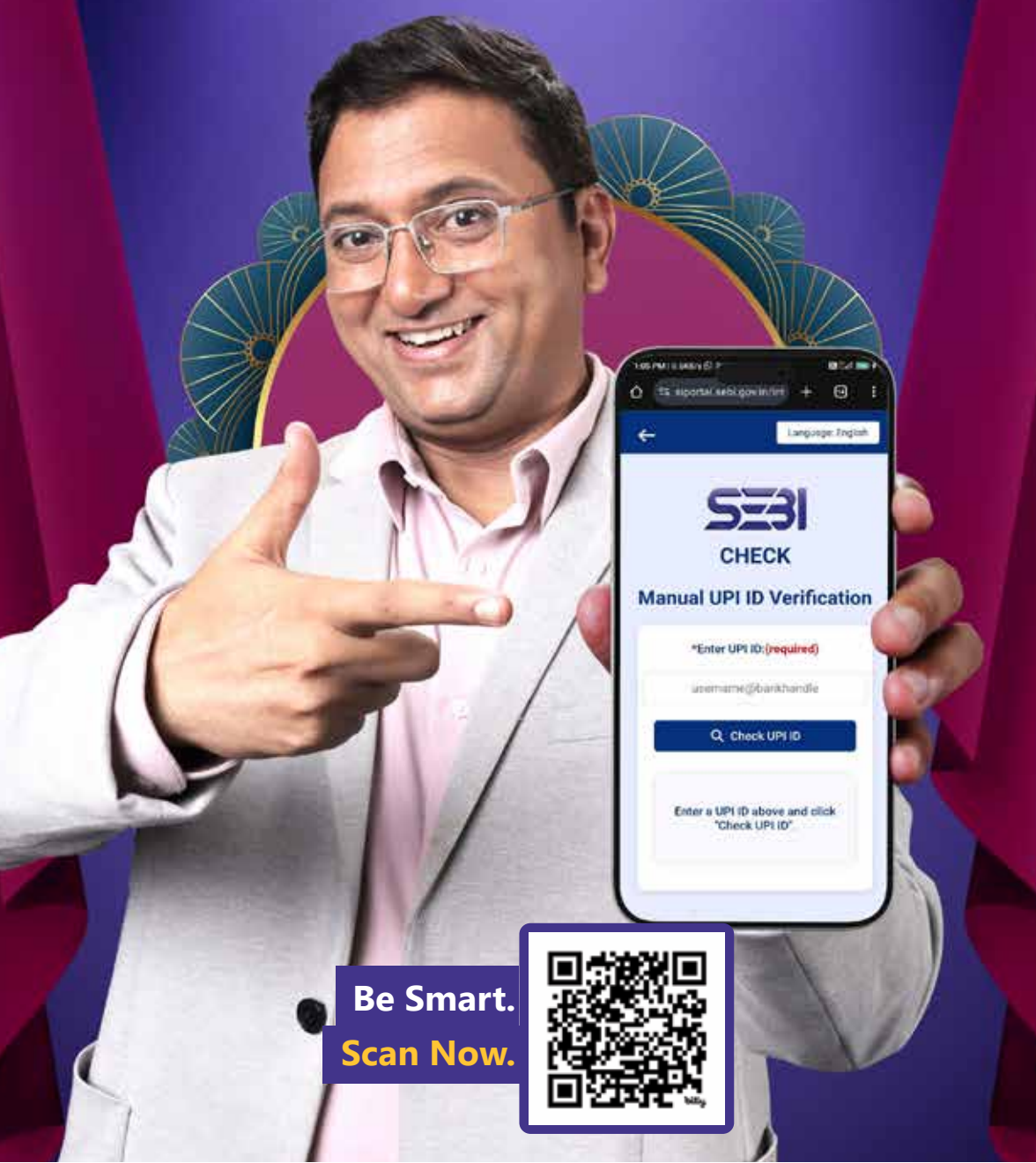
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Watchman assaulted with stick and crushed twice by SUV in Peeragarhi

Victim attempted to flee towards main road after first impact, police said

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: An SUV driver assaulted a 60-year-old watchman with a stick, and then ran him over twice with his vehicle as the man fled, killing him, in Peeragarhi village on Sunday, police said.

The deceased Bijender Bhardwaj, a resident of the village in outer Delhi, worked as a watchman at the tempo stand where the incident occurred.

Police said CCTV footage shows the vehicle waiting in one corner with its headlights on for a few minutes while the victim sat on a chair in the opposite direction.

Detailing the sequence of events, police said a man stepped out of the vehicle carrying a large stick and attacked the victim without apparent provocation. As the victim tried to save himself, the accused returned to the SUV, ran him over once, and pushed him toward a corner, police said.

When the victim attempted



The accused fled the area around 2.54 am after the second collision FILE

to escape by running towards the main road, the accused again ran him over a second time, and fled the scene around 2:54 am, they said.

“CCTV footage in and around the area revealed that the deceased was run over twice by a four-wheeler. The footage is being examined thoroughly to identify the vehicle and reconstruct the exact sequence of events and what led to the matter,” the officer said.

According to the FIR, the accused stepped out of the vehicle at around 2:52 am.

Police found skid marks at the scene during inspection, indicating the vehicle had braked before or during the incident. The deceased’s relative said the victim had no enmity or dispute with anyone.

“We learned about the incident around 3:30 pm. My uncle has been working here as a security guard for one year. He was a simple man,” said Sunil

TAKEAWAYS

» The police reached the spot and checked the CCTV footage, but the vehicle’s number plate is not visible in the footage

» No eyewitnesses were found in the area, and efforts are underway to gather further evidence in the case; CCTV footage from nearby roads is being scanned: Cops

Bhardwaj, the victim’s nephew. “The police reached the spot and checked the CCTV footage, but the vehicle’s number plate is not visible in the footage,” he said.

The FIR also stated that no eyewitnesses were found in the area, and efforts are underway to gather further evidence in the case. The police said they are scanning CCTV footage from nearby roads, traffic intersections and commercial establishments to track

the SUV’s movement.

Police said a case under sections 103(1) (murder) and 3(5) (common intentions) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) has been registered at Paschim Vihar West police station. Efforts are underway to ascertain its registration number and ownership details.

Multiple teams have been deployed to trace the accused driver and the vehicle involved, the police said. Forensic and other teams inspected the scene and collected forensic and technical evidence. An analysis of CCTV footage indicated that the victim may have been deliberately targeted, a police officer told PTL, adding that they were probing all angles.

The police said a PCR call regarding the incident was received at around 4.03 am on Sunday, following which the local team rushed to the spot.

Bijender was found lying unconscious on the road and was rushed to a nearby hospital, where he was declared brought dead.

GYMKHANA CLUB

Capital’s exclusive address; CP architect designed its building

NEW DELHI: Tucked in a leafy enclave in the heart of the city, the Delhi Gymkhana Club, an exclusive address that seamlessly combines history, power and access for the select few, has for over a century retained its quiet elegance and colonial-era charm.

Its current home -- the majestic white building endowed with its famed ballroom, and surrounded by carefully manicured lawns, sits on a sprawling 27.3-acre plot at 2, Safdarjung Road, and was envisioned by architect Robert Tor Russell, who also designed the famed Connaught Place complex and the erstwhile Commander-in-Chief’s house (now Teen Murti Bhawan) in Delhi.

However, this nearly uninterrupted legacy of more than 110 years, which has defined wealth, power and social status, not ostentatiously but quietly, may soon come to an end, as the Centre has asked the historic club to hand over its premises by June 5, saying the land parcel was required for “strengthening and securing defence infrastructure” and for other vital public security purposes.



In its May 22 order, the Land and Development Office (L&DO) under the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs, seeking “re-entry and resumption”, has said that the land falls in a highly sensitive and strategic zone and was critically required for urgent institutional and governance-related needs. The move has triggered debates on TV channels and on social media platforms, with some dubbing the club a “vestige” of the colonial era, while others argue that this recreational space -- a Lutyens’ Delhi showpiece -- is steeped in history and heritage that must be acknowledged without any bias.

Originally founded on July 3, 1913, as the Imperial Delhi Gymkhana Club, the

institution was established to primarily serve colonial administrators and military officers.

The word ‘Imperial’ was dropped after India gained Independence in 1947, but the club continued to maintain its premium property and the imperial charm of yesteryears, its swimming pool, tennis courts, billiards table, and the majestic ballroom with a wooden floor, attracting the who’s who of society.

Founded in 1913, the Delhi Gymkhana Club remains one of India’s most exclusive institutions, closely tied to the making of New Delhi. Designed by Robert Tor Russell, its elite membership and colonial legacy continue to define its enduring stature. PTL

News at a glance

AIIMS ORGA-NISES POSTER COMPETITION

NEW DELHI: The Centre for Integrative Medicine and Research (CIMR), AIIMS New Delhi, will organise an on-the-spot poster-making competition on June 10 on the theme “Yoga for World Peace”. The event will be held from 9 am to 12 noon at Foyer-II and the Conference Hall of AIIMS employees and students. Winners will receive cash prizes, organisers said. Participants have been asked to bring their own brushes and colours. Registrations for the competition are open till June 10 through an online Google form.

90 KG ‘GANJA’ SEIZED; 1 HELD

NEW DELHI: Police has busted an interstate narcotics smuggling racket with the seizure of over 90 kg of ‘ganja’ from outer north Delhi’s Bawana area and arrested one person, officials said on Sunday. The accused, Abdul Rehman alias Bablu, allegedly stored the contraband at his residence. Police recovered four sacks containing 90.225 kg of ganja hidden inside a deep freezer. Investigation is underway to trace other syndicate members.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NOIDA: A 26-year-old executive working at a private company in Noida was arrested for allegedly carrying out a series of attacks on women using scissors in the city’s Sector 55 area, police said on Sunday.

The accused, identified as Ankit Verma, a resident of Khoda Colony in Ghaziabad, allegedly targeted women walking alone on deserted stretches and attacked them below the waist before fleeing on his scooter.

Police said the incidents created panic among residents after two women were attacked within a short span on the same evening in Sector 58 Police Station limits.

According to officials, the accused was arrested within a day of the complaints being filed. Officers recovered the scooter used in the crime and a broken piece of scissors allegedly used in the attacks.

“He told police that he attacked the women ‘for entertainment’ and out of resentment towards them”

Additional DCP Noida Manisha Singh said two women approached Sector 58 Police Station on Friday and reported that a scooter-borne man had attacked them from behind with a sharp object while they were returning home through Sector 55 road.

One of the victims, Aanshi Kumar, originally from Unnau and currently living in a PG accommodation in Sector 56, told police that she was walking near DAV School in Sector 55 around 6.21 pm on Tuesday when a man wearing a white T-shirt on a blue scooter suddenly attacked her with a sharp

object on her lower back and sped away. She suffered bleeding injuries and was rushed to a nearby hospital by passersby.

Soon after, another woman, Asha Bhandari, a resident of Sector 22, was similarly attacked by the accused in the same area. She too sustained injuries and underwent treatment at a nearby hospital before filing a complaint.

Police formed multiple teams and used local intelligence inputs and electronic surveillance to trace the accused. During interrogation, Verma allegedly confessed to attacking four to five women. Police said he claimed he committed the assaults “for entertainment” and due to resentment towards women.

Officials said Verma is married, a graduate, and had been working as an executive at a private company in Sector 62 since 2020. Police are now trying to identify other possible victims in the case.

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: A 31-year-old man died after being brutally stabbed by a group of assailants in Outer North Delhi’s Shahbad Dairy area, following which Delhi Police arrested a 20-year-old suspect, officials said.

The accused has been identified as Suraj (20), son of Shivani and a resident of Shahbad Dairy.

Police said the deceased, Narayan Dutt, son of Ram Babu, was a resident of Gupta Colony in Prahladpur, Delhi.

According to police, information regarding the stabbing incident was received through a PCR call at Shahbad Dairy Police Station on May 23. A police team rushed to Mahadev Chowk in Shahbad Dairy and later reached Maharishi Valmiki Hospital in Pooth Khurd, where the injured man had been admitted for treatment.



Narayan Dutt had sustained multiple sharp-edged injuries in the attack. His Medico-Legal Case (MLC) report mentioned an alleged history of stabbing, and doctors initially declared him unfit to give a statement due to his critical condition, police said.

During the preliminary investigation, police examined CCTV footage installed near the crime scene. Officials said the footage showed three youths allegedly assaulting the victim before fleeing the spot. Based on the findings, a

case was registered at Shahbad Dairy Police Station under relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), including Sections 109(1) and 3(5).

Later, Section 103(1) of the BNS relating to murder was added after Narayan Dutt succumbed to his injuries and was declared brought dead at Safdarjung Hospital.

Police said multiple teams were formed to identify and trace the accused persons. Investigators have been analysing CCTV footage from nearby areas and conducting raids at possible hideouts to track down the remaining suspects involved in the murder.

During the course of the investigation, one of the alleged assailants, Suraj, was apprehended, police said.

Efforts are underway to arrest the remaining accused persons, while the motive behind the attack is yet to be ascertained, officials added.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

FARIDABAD: A Bangladeshi engineering student allegedly died by suicide in the hostel of a private college on the Surajkund-Faridabad Road in Faridabad, police said on Sunday.

The deceased was identified as Mustaq, a Bangladeshi national studying engineering at the institute. According to police, he shared a hostel room on the second floor with another student, who was away at work when the incident took place on Saturday evening.

When the roommate returned, he allegedly found Mustaq hanging from a ceiling fan. With the help of other students, he rushed him to a nearby private hospital, where doctors declared him brought dead.

Police said preliminary findings suggest a possible affair angle, though the matter is still under investigation. PTL

Special Cell bust Nandu gang plot to open fire at southwest Delhi clinic for extortion

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police’s Special Cell has arrested five alleged sharpshooters linked to the notorious Kapil Sangwan alias Nandu gang for allegedly plotting a firing incident at a clinic in southwest Delhi’s Chhawla area as part of an extortion racket, officials said.

The accused have been identified as Abhishek, Sahil, and Harshdeep alias Polu, all residents of Amritsar in Punjab, along with Karan alias Ankush and Aman, both residents of Kaithal in Haryana.

Police said three semi-automatic pistols, four live cartridges and three mobile phones used for communica-



tion with gang members were recovered from their possession. According to officials, the operation was carried out on March 20 by a team of the Special Cell’s Northern Range led by Inspectors Anuj Nautiyal and Chandan Kumar under the supervision of ACP Rahul Kumar Singh.

The arrests followed sustained technical and manual surveillance on organised

criminal gangs operating across Delhi-NCR.

Police said they had received specific intelligence inputs suggesting that Kapil Sangwan alias Nandu, who is allegedly operating the extortion network from abroad, had hired Punjab-based shooters to target a prominent location in southwest Delhi.

During the investigation, officials found that the gang members had conducted reconnaissance of the clinic in February and were planning to execute the attack later.

Police said Abhishek disclosed during interrogation that he and his associates had travelled to Delhi on Nandu’s directions to open fire at the clinic for extortion purposes.

According to investigators, arms, ammunition and a motorcycle were arranged through gang associates based in Kaithal. However, the accused allegedly failed to execute the attack due to a heavy crowd presence near the clinic and instead carried out a reconnaissance before returning, police said.

Based on Abhishek’s disclosure, police traced and arrested Sahil, Harshdeep, Karan and Aman. Investigators said Harshdeep was in direct contact with Kapil Sangwan and had recruited the other shooters for monetary gain.

Police said the arrests have significantly disrupted the gang’s extortion network and helped avert a major firing incident in the national capital.

TWO-DAY CRACKDOWN

Cops book 1,170 for wrong-side driving

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Traffic Police has registered 1,170 FIRs and impounded 1,179 vehicles during a special two-day city-wide crackdown against wrong-side driving, an official said on Sunday.

The enforcement drive was conducted on May 22 and 23 across major roads, intersections, highways and accident-prone stretches in the national capital to curb the dangerous practice of motorists driving against the flow of traffic.



According to the police, a total of 12,568 challans were also issued during the operation against violators found flouting traffic norms by driving on the wrong

“Conducted across major roads, intersections, highways, accident-prone stretches across the city”

side of the road.

A senior officer said wrong-side driving has emerged as one of the major causes of road accidents, disorderly traffic movement and head-on collisions in the city.

“Wrong-side driving is not merely a traffic violation. It is a grave and life-threatening offence that endangers innocent road users and severely disrupts traffic flow,” the officer said. The police said strict legal action, including registration of criminal cases, seizure of vehicles and prosecution, has been initiated against offenders.

Delhi Traffic Police also issued a stern warning that anyone found indulging in wrong-side driving would face strict legal consequences.

Gzb neighbour shoots man after census row

GHAZIABAD: A dispute over sharing census-related information allegedly turned violent in Ghaziabad’s Muradnagar area after a 55-year-old man was shot by his neighbour, police said on Sunday.

The victim, identified as Virendra Tyagi, sustained a gunshot injury while sitting in the verandah of his house in Adarsh Nagar Colony on Saturday night. He was rushed to a nearby hospital, where his condition remains critical. Police have detained the accused, Rampal Chaudhary, who lives

in the same neighbourhood.

According to officials, the two men had an ongoing dispute over minor neighbourhood issues. During preliminary questioning, the accused allegedly claimed he was upset after Tyagi accompanied census officials to his house and helped them with information related to the ongoing enumeration exercise. Chaudhary allegedly opened fire at Tyagi outside his home. Weapon used in the crime is being examined; further inquiry is underway. MPOST



A traffic police personnel uses an electric hand fan and AC helmet on a summer day, in New Delhi, Sunday

City sizzles at 43.6°C Yellow alert for next 3 days

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi recorded a maximum temperature of 43.6 degrees Celsius, 3.4 notches above the seasonal average, according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD). The minimum temperature settled at 28.4 degrees Celsius on Sunday morning, two notches above the seasonal average, it stated. The maximum temperature across various weather stations in Delhi-NCR remained significantly above normal on Sunday, with the Ridge and Ayanagar stations recording the highest temperature at 44.6 degrees Celsius each. Lodhi Road recorded a maximum temperature of 43.8 degrees Celsius, followed by Palam at 43.7 degrees Celsius and Safdarjung at 43.6 degrees Celsius. The departure from normal ranged between 2.3 degrees Celsius and 4.8 degrees Celsius, indicating prevailing heatwave-like conditions in several parts of the city. Meanwhile, the minimum temperature also stayed above normal at most stations. Safdarjung recorded a minimum temperature of 28.7 degrees Celsius, while Ridge registered 27.2 degrees Celsius and Palam 27.6 degrees Celsius. Lodhi Road and Ayanagar recorded minimum temperatures of 26.8 degrees Celsius and 26.3 degrees Celsius, respectively. The departures from normal minimum tem-

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The minimum temperature settled at 28.4 degrees Celsius on Sunday morning, two notches above the seasonal average
- » The air quality was recorded in the 'poor' category at 4 pm, with an Air Quality Index reading of 205

peratures ranged from minus 0.4 degrees Celsius to plus 2 degrees Celsius. The weather department has predicted a yellow alert for strong surface winds and a heatwave in the afternoon and evening for the next three days. The maximum and minimum temperatures are expected to hover around 44 and 30 degrees Celsius, respectively, on Monday. Relative humidity oscillated between 37 per cent and 18 per cent throughout the day. The air quality was recorded in the 'poor' category at 4 pm, with an Air Quality Index (AQI) reading of 205. Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) data showed. According to the CPCB, an AQI between zero and 50 is considered 'good', 51 to 100 'satisfactory', 101 to 200 'moderate', 201 to 300 'poor', 301 to 400 'very poor', and 401 to 500 'severe'.

MCD intensifies 'Dust-Free Roads' drive across Capital

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Municipal Corporation (MCD) has intensified its city-wide "Dust-Free Roads" and special sanitation campaign across all 12 zones as part of the Swachh Bharat Mission, aiming to improve urban cleanliness and reduce dust pollution in the Capital. The civic body has deployed mechanised road sweeping machines, water sprinklers, jetting machines and sanitation workers on major roads and public spaces to strengthen dust-control measures and maintain cleanliness standards. In the Karol Bagh zone, a 15-day "Dust-Free Roads" campaign launched on May 18 covered key stretches including Girdhari Lal Goswami Marg, Vande Mataram Marg, Shankar Road, Rani Jhansi Road, D.B. Gupta Road and Najafgarh Road. According to MCD officials, nearly 15.2 km of roads were cleaned by May 21, with around 20.8 metric tonnes of dust and 9.2 metric tonnes of waste removed during the operation.



Similar drives were undertaken in the South Zone on major arterial roads such as Dhaula Kuan AIIMS stretch, Nelson Mandela Marg, Aurobindo Marg and Africa Avenue. Civic authorities deployed 100-150 sanitation workers along with mechanised equipment across an area of nearly 8-10 sq km, removing over 20 metric tonnes of dust and waste. Special sanitation

campaigns were also conducted in City SP Zone, Rohini and West Zone, where cleaning of roads, footpaths, green belts and public utility areas was carried out using anti-smog guns and mechanised cleaning systems. The MCD said it would continue regular monitoring and public participation initiatives to ensure a cleaner, dust-free and healthier urban environment across Delhi.

NEW STPs AMONG KEY CLEANUP PROJECTS

Delhi pumps ₹1K cr into Yamuna revival

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a major push towards Yamuna rejuvenation and strengthening Delhi's water infrastructure, the government led by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta has approved a series of water management and sewage treatment projects worth more than Rs 1,000 crore. The initiatives include new decentralised sewage treatment plants, expansion of existing treatment capacity, rehabilitation of ageing sewer infrastructure and measures to improve groundwater recharge through rainwater harvesting. Announcing the projects on Sunday, the Chief Minister said the government was working in "mission mode" to clean the Yamuna River and reduce pollution flowing through the Najafgarh Drain. "Building a

clean, green and water-secure capital is our priority," she said, adding that the projects were aimed at improving public infrastructure and ensuring better civic services for residents across Delhi. A major component of the plan involves setting up 12 new Decentralised Sewage Treatment Plants (DSTPs) in the Najafgarh region under the Centre's AMRUT scheme at an estimated cost of around Rs 860 crore. The plants will together have a sewage treatment capacity of 46.5 MGD. According to officials, a 17 MGD plant will be established at Mitraon, while additional DSTPs will come up in Kair, Kanganheri, Kakrola, Dichaon Kalan, Galibpur, Sarangpur, Shikarpur, Hasanpur, Jaffarpur, Kazipur and Khara Dabar. The projects are

MISSION MODE

- » Announcing the projects on Sunday, the CM said the govt was working in 'mission mode' to clean the Yamuna River and reduce pollution flowing through the Najafgarh Drain
- » Building a clean, green and water-secure capital is our priority: CM Rekha Gupta



expected to benefit more than 121 unauthorised colonies, 35 villages and nearly seven lakh residents. The government said the new facilities would help stop untreated sewage from entering the Najafgarh Drain,

thereby contributing to the larger Yamuna cleaning effort and environmental protection measures. The Chief Minister also announced the upgradation of Phase I of the Keshopur Sewage Treatment Plant, where treat-

ment capacity will be increased from 12 MGD to 18 MGD at a cost of approximately Rs.122 crore. "The project will ensure treated water meets the latest prescribed standards and will promote the use of recycled water," she said.

In another key decision, the Delhi Jal Board will construct new rainwater harvesting structures and restore existing ones across departments to improve groundwater levels and strengthen water security in the capital. Four groundwater experts and ten rainwater harvesting social mobilisers will also be appointed for implementation and awareness activities. The government has additionally approved rehabilitation of a decades-old trunk sewer line from Amichand Chowk to the Old Kalyanpuri Sewage Pumping Station in Trilokpur at a cost of nearly Rs.57 crore. A new underground reservoir and booster pumping station will also be developed in Rohas Nagar for around Rs.27 crore to improve water supply in the area.

Delhi Metro expands global outreach

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA



NEW DELHI: Countries including Israel, Egypt and Kenya have approached the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) for possible collaboration in metro projects, with the corporation now looking to expand its international presence through a dedicated overseas arm as it seeks additional revenue to modernise ageing infrastructure in the national capital, Managing Director Vikas Kumar said. In an interview to PTI, Kumar said DMRC is currently associated with metro projects in Dhaka, where it is providing consultancy support, assisting in project execution and helping in operations and maintenance (O&M). "Right now we are associated with Dhaka. We are working there as consultants and also helping them in executing the project. In O&M also, we are supporting them," he said. Kumar said countries

such as Israel and Egypt had approached DMRC in the past regarding possible metro collaborations. Some African nations, including Kenya, had also shown interest in engaging with the corporation, though discussions have not progressed further. To strengthen its international operations, DMRC has formed Delhi Metro International Limited (DMIL), a separate company focused on securing projects abroad. "We have formed a new

company, Delhi Metro International Limited, and now very aggressively we are trying to get some contracts abroad," Kumar said. Kumar said revenue generated through projects outside Delhi would help the corporation undertake refurbishment and modernisation work across the Delhi Metro network, parts of which are now over two decades old. "Our stock has become old. Stations have become quite old. More than two decades have passed since operations started

in 2002, so it requires certain mid-life refurbishments. For that we require money. So we have to generate more additional revenue other than ticketing from Delhi," he said. According to Kumar, DMRC is also planning to engage with embassies and international organisations and is exploring partnerships with foreign firms to strengthen its global experience in urban mobility projects. Kumar said DMRC's expertise in operating driverless metro systems could become a key strength in attracting overseas projects. "We are one of the largest metro systems having this driverless experience. More than 90 kilometres of our network is driverless," he said. Apart from overseas engagements, DMRC has secured long-term O&M contracts for Mumbai Metro and Chennai Metro, while it is also providing operational support in Patna, Noida, Gurugram and Jaipur, Kumar added.

WOMAN, 1-YEAR-OLD SON FOUND DEAD

FARIDABAD: A 28-year-old woman and her infant son were found dead in a village in the Surajkund area here, police said, adding that the woman's family has accused her in-laws of poisoning her to death. A case of murder has been registered based on the complaint by the woman's family and the cause of death will be revealed after the post-mortem report is received, Surajkund SHO Prahlad Singh said. The deceased, Aarti and her son Hriday, were residents of Ankhir village. Upon receiving the information, a police team and a forensic team reached the spot and sent the bodies to the ESIC Medical College Hospital for post-mortem, police said. Subsequently, the police handed over the bodies to the family, they added. During the investigation, the police found that Aarti lived on the first floor of the house with her husband, Nishant and their one-year-old son.

10-MONTH-OLD GIRL KIDNAPPED

NEW DELHI: A 10-month-old girl was allegedly kidnapped from a Mukundpur house here in the early Sunday morning when her father stepped out to buy milk, triggering panic in the locality, an official said. Police said crime and local police teams are making efforts to trace the child. The child's grandfather said his son returned home and could not find the infant. "We then called people from the neighbourhood and started searching for her, but we could not find her. We informed the police, and the hunt is on," the grandfather said. The infant's mother, Surya, said when her husband returned after buying milk, he found her and their elder daughter in an unconscious state. "He woke me up by calling out my name and shaking me. When I regained consciousness, I found that even my elder daughter was unconscious. We woke her up too, and then realised that our youngest daughter was missing, but we had no idea where she was. I do not even step outside, so I do not know who took my child," Surya said.

COPS BUST CHINESE MANJHA RACKET

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police has busted an illegal Chinese manjha racket and arrested two men after recovering 2,040 rolls of banned synthetic kite string from the Uttam Nagar area, an officer said on Sunday. Police said the seizure potentially prevented several fatal accidents and serious injuries to pedestrians, bikers, children, and birds, as incidents involving hazardous synthetic manjha witness a spike during festive and kite-flying seasons. The accused have been identified as Shanky Singhal alias Kaalu, 36, and Manmohan, 52, both residents of Uttam Nagar, he said. According to police, the operation was carried out by the Crime Branch following a tip-off about the illegal storage of banned Chinese manjha at Hanuman Market in Uttam Nagar. During the raid, police recovered 34 cartons containing 60 rolls each of synthetic kite string from a ground-floor premises in the market. "The banned manjha was being stocked for sale ahead of the Independence Day kite-flying season. During interrogation, Shanky disclosed that he had procured the consignment from a wholesale kite trader, Manmohan, based in Uttam Nagar, to earn quick profits during the festive season," the officer said.

FOLLOWING CM REKHA GUPTA'S INTERVENTION

8-year wait ends, 36 Harsh Vihar homes get power connections

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: After nearly eight years of living in darkness and depending on temporary power arrangements, 36 families in North-East Delhi's Harsh Vihar finally received regular electricity connections on Sunday, with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta personally handing over the connections at the Jan Seva Sadan. The development came after residents raised the issue during a public grievance hearing, prompting the Delhi government to intervene in what officials described as a "mission mode" operation. The families from Harsh

Vihar's A-3 block in Gokulpuri thanked the Chief Minister for resolving what they called a long-pending crisis that had affected their daily lives since 2018. North-East Delhi MP Manoj Tiwari was also present during the programme. Addressing the gathering, Rekha Gupta said, "The satisfaction visible on the faces of these families reflects how responsive governance and timely action can bring meaningful change to people's lives." She added that the government's objective was "not merely to launch schemes but to address people's real problems and ensure that basic services reach every resident."

“The satisfaction visible on the faces of these families reflects how responsive governance and timely action can bring meaningful change to people's lives — CM

According to officials, around 50 to 60 houses had come up in Harsh Vihar's A-3 block by 2018, but residents could not get regular electricity supply because land was unavailable for an Electric Sub-Station (ESS) required for power infrastructure. As a result, many families continued to live without authorised power connections, while others

relied on temporary and unorganised arrangements. The Chief Minister said residents had approached her during a public grievance hearing and informed her about the years-long delay in securing electricity connections. Taking note of the matter, she directed officials and concerned agencies to coordinate and resolve the issue at the earliest. Following the inter-

vention, land was arranged for transformer installation and the power distribution company expanded the electricity network across the locality. Officials said electrification work has now been completed and electricity meters are being installed for eligible applicants. Rekha Gupta said, "Public grievance hearings are not merely a platform for registering complaints but an effective mechanism for ensuring quick resolution of citizens' problems." She also directed officials to ensure that the remaining families in the area receive connections within the stipulated timeframe.



Feared Manipur-like crisis in Ladakh, talks bring hope: Wangchuk

Continued from Page 1
Wangchuk said the order related to his release had spoken of creating “an environment of trust” and pursuing “meaningful and constructive dialogue”, but he claimed the situation in Ladakh had not matched those assurances. “Nothing was happening on the ground. People were getting divided, Leh and Kargil, Buddhists fighting Buddhists, Muslims fighting Muslims. We felt trust-building was not happening, and meaningful dialogue seemed unlikely,” he said.

Describing recent tensions, Wangchuk said the atmosphere last week had become deeply concerning. “There was conflict everywhere. I thought Ladakh would become another Manipur; it was heading in that direction,” he said. He said the latest engagement offered some relief, noting that “both sides have taken a step”, but added that the Centre’s intent would become clear only if pending concerns were addressed. Among those issues, Wangchuk pointed to the continued seizure of his

mobile phone, taken during protests around eight months ago. He said more than two months after his release, the device had not been returned. “Without it, I cannot book an Ola, an Uber, or even a plane ticket. Digitally, I have become useless in Digital India,” he said, adding that he had chosen not to replace it on principle. “The government has left me half free and kept the other half in jail.” He also raised concerns over the Himalayan Institute of Alternatives, Ladakh, saying its land lease was cancelled despite

proper documentation and that its FCRA licence had not been restored despite scrutiny finding no wrongdoing. “The question arises, was I released out of sympathy or because of the Supreme Court’s intervention?” he asked. Wangchuk said the biggest trust issue remained cases linked to the September 24 protests, citing injuries, deaths and criminal charges against demonstrators. “Will those cases be withdrawn? Only then will there be trust,” he said. His remarks came after

the Leh Apex Body and Kargil Democratic Alliance met the MHA panel on constitutional safeguards, governance and democratic powers. The groups have sought statehood, land and job protections, and greater democratic rights since Ladakh became a Union Territory without a legislature in 2019. After Thursday’s meeting, both said an “in-principle understanding” had been reached on restoring democracy and extending Article 371-type constitutional safeguards similar to Nagaland, Sikkim and Mizoram. AGENCIES

J&K: Missing 12-yr-old girl allegedly raped, killed in Budgam

OUR CORRESPONDENT
SRINAGAR: A 12-year-old girl, who was reported missing in Jammu and Kashmir’s Budgam district, was found murdered around 200 metres from her house on Sunday, police said. A senior police officer said the girl was reported missing on Saturday evening from Galwanpora area of the district. “A case of kidnapping a minor child was registered and searches were carried out. Unfortunately, the body of the child was found today morning,” SSP Budgam Hariprasad K K said. He said the body was sent for post-mortem examination. “Prima facie it seems to be a case of rape and murder. We have

added the relevant sections of the law to the FIR,” he said. Meanwhile, chief preacher of Kashmiri Mirwaiz Umar Farooq said he was “heartbroken and deeply disturbed” by the incident. “The circumstances surrounding this incident are extremely painful and have shaken the conscience of every human being,” he said. The Mirwaiz said such incidents spread fear, grief, and deep anxiety among people and demand serious introspection at every level. “What are we becoming as a society if our children cannot even feel safe on their way to seek education and guidance?” he asked.

CEC Gyanesh Kumar reviews SIR preparations in Uttarakhand

OUR CORRESPONDENT
DEHRADUN: Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar reviewed the preparations for the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls at a high-level meeting here on Sunday. The review meeting took place at the State Guest House in Bijapur on the second day of the CEC’s visit to Uttarakhand. Kumar said the main objective of the SIR is to refine the voters’ list by identifying absent, shifted, deceased, duplicate and foreign voters.

Rainfall raises water level of Nainital’s Naini Lake by 9 inch above 2-yr average

NAINITAL: Late rainfall pushed the water level of Nainital’s iconic Naini Lake nine inches above the two-year average to reach 79 feet 9 inches on Sunday despite scant winter rain and snowfall this year, officials said. The Irrigation Department attributed this vital recharge to unseasonal drains that channelled water into the lake during May and late August. At present, the water level decreases by about half an inch daily to meet the drinking water supply demands of the Nainital town. “Even if there is no rainfall in May, the water level is expected to reach 77 feet after June 10,” Irrigation Department Executive Engineer D K Singh said. The region recorded 275 mm of rainfall from January to May this year. In comparison, the water level stood at 79 feet with 140 mm of rainfall during the same period in 2025. The lake recorded 79 feet with 72 mm of rainfall in 2024,

while 2023 saw a level of 82 feet 1 inch with 445 mm of rainfall. An unusually harsh summer hit Nainital in 2025, but abundant monsoon rains later replenished the reservoir to a peak of 12 feet, the officials pointed out. The Irrigation Department regularly released excess water from the lake during September last year. Officials use four British-era exit gates, locally known as “daanth”, to monitor and discharge excess water when required. Measurement scales marked on these gates indicate the water level, where the zero mark represents the lowest level during peak summer. Experts said Naini Lake largely depends on underground natural water sources and surrounding oak forests to retain and recharge groundwater. Traditional rainwater harvesting systems, locally called “patnalas”, used to allow rainwater to seep into the ground. AGENCIES

Heatwave conditions to persist across India till May-end: IMD

Continued from Page 1
Delhi continued to bake under high temperatures, with the national capital recording a maximum of 43.6 degrees Celsius, which was 3.4 degrees above the seasonal average. Among various weather stations, Ayanagar and Ridge were the hottest at 44.6 degrees Celsius each. Lodhi Road recorded 43.8 degrees, Palam 43.7 degrees, and Safdarjung 43.6 degrees Celsius. In Uttar Pradesh, temperatures remained high across several cities. Lucknow recorded a maximum of 42.6 degrees Celsius, 2.4 degrees above normal, while the minimum settled at 28.7 degrees Celsius, 3.2

degrees above average. Banda remained the hottest location in the country at 46.8 degrees Celsius, 3.3 degrees above normal. Prayagraj, Orai and Jhansi each recorded 45.6 degrees Celsius. Agra registered 45.4 degrees, while Hamirpur touched 45.2 degrees Celsius. Neighbouring Rajasthan also faced severe heat, with temperatures in several areas ranging between 45 and 46 degrees Celsius. Sri Ganganagar recorded the state’s highest temperature at 46 degrees Celsius, followed by Vanasthali at 45.1 degrees. Churu registered 44.9 degrees, while Kota, Phalodi and Bikaner each recorded 44.8 degrees. Jaipur touched 43.6 degrees Celsius.

The Jaipur meteorological centre issued a heatwave alert, saying dry weather is likely to continue across most parts of Rajasthan for the next three to four days. Officials warned that temperatures in parts of western Rajasthan may rise further to 46-47 degrees Celsius on May 26 and 27. Relief may arrive later in the week, with the IMD forecasting a fresh western disturbance from May 28-29. This could bring thunderstorms, winds of 50-60 kmph and light rainfall in some parts of the state. “This is likely to lower maximum temperatures by 2-3 degrees Celsius,” the department said. Haryana and Punjab also remained in the

grip of hot weather. Sirsa recorded 46 degrees Celsius, making it Haryana’s hottest location. Rohtak logged 45.3 degrees and Bhiwani 44 degrees. Ambala recorded 42 degrees, Hisar 43.8 degrees, Karnal 42.8 degrees and Gurugram 41.7 degrees. Chandigarh recorded 40.9 degrees Celsius. In Andhra Pradesh, authorities reported mixed conditions, with some districts facing extreme heat while isolated areas may receive rainfall and thunderstorms in the coming days. The Andhra Pradesh State Disaster Management Authority warned that severe heatwave conditions are expected to continue for the next three days.

Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar residence of CJP founder given police protection

OUR CORRESPONDENT
CHHATRAPATI SAMBHAJINAGAR: Police protection has been provided at the residence of Cockroach Janata Party founder Abhijeet Dipke in MIDC Waluj area of Maharashtra’s Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar, a senior official said on Sunday. The Cockroach Janta Party emerged online last week and rapidly gained traction through memes and political commentary around unemployment, examination paper leaks and education-related issues. “We have given round-the-clock general police protection to Abhijeet Dipke’s residence located in MIDC Waluj area. This is to ensure there is no crowding at his place since the CJP issue is trending on social media right now,” Deputy Commissioner of Police Pan-

The Cockroach Janta Party emerged online last week and rapidly gained traction through memes and political commentary

kaj Atulkar told news agency. Atulkar denied the protection was due to threats, asserting that none of the police stations under his jurisdiction had received any formal complaint in this regard. Incidentally, Dipke on Saturday alleged a sweeping crackdown on the digital movement, claiming all its social media accounts and its website have been taken down or compromised, leaving the group without access to any of its official platforms.

From Page 1 Jaishankar

imposed punitive tariffs on India and President Donald Trump made claims about his role in calming tensions during the India-Pakistan military clashes last May. Rubio was firm that none of this had weakened the core of the partnership. “India is an important strategic partner of the United States, one of our most important strategic partners in the world,” he said, adding that the relationship would be stronger by the end of the current administration. On India’s part, Jaishankar used the occasion to spell out a five-point framework guiding the country’s approach to global affairs. India, he said, supports dialogue and diplomacy to resolve conflicts, backs safe and unimpeded maritime commerce, demands respect for international law, opposes the use of market access and resources as weapons, and believes in trusted partnerships to strengthen global supply chains. The remarks offered a window into how India sees itself in a world of competing pressures, from the war in Ukraine to tensions in West Asia. Much of the conversation, according to people familiar with the talks, touched on the West Asia crisis and what it means for India’s energy needs. Jaishankar raised concerns about how the situation around the Strait of Hormuz has pushed up costs and caused economic strain. “The way we will deal with the current situation in Hormuz and going forward as well, is to diversify our energy sources, because that is at the heart of our energy security,” he said. “It is important to keep energy prices down for global growth.” He noted that India has good ties with the United States, Israel, Iran and Gulf countries, putting it in a position few others can claim. “We don’t look at it as a zero-sum game,” he said. On the energy front, Jaishankar pointed to a “very significant uptick” in India’s energy imports from the US, describing shared interest in keeping global

energy markets open and prices stable. Rubio struck an optimistic note on the trade front, saying the two sides were close to finalising a deal. “We’ve made tremendous progress, and I think we’re going to wind up with a trade agreement between the US and India that is going to be enduring and is going to be beneficial to both sides,” he said. Jaishankar brought up terrorism as a shared challenge, calling India’s position one of “zero tolerance.” He pointed to the extradition from the US last year of a key planner of the 2008 Mumbai attacks as a sign of what cooperation between the two countries can deliver. Both sides agreed to keep working together on counter-terrorism bilaterally and through international forums. On the sidelines, Rubio also met National Security Advisor Ajit Doval. Their talks covered defence, security and strategic technology, including something called the TRUST initiative. The US embassy said the discussion focused on counter-terrorism cooperation and stability in the Indo-Pacific. Jaishankar later described the day’s talks as “good discussions,” saying the two sides reviewed the full scope of the Comprehensive Global Strategic Partnership, covering trade, energy, defence, critical minerals, artificial intelligence, nuclear cooperation and counter-narcotics. He also noted that Rubio would join India, Australia and Japan for a QUAD Foreign Ministers’ meeting on Tuesday.

Trump joins

“India can count on me 100 per cent. They call right here. We’re doing well. We’re setting records. We have a record economy, a record stock market and anything India wants to get. I am a big, big fan of Prime Minister Modi.” Trump also praised US Secretary of State Marco Rubio, who is in India for the Quad Foreign Ministers’ Meeting. “Marco is the greatest. He is going down as the greatest Secretary of State in the history of our country,” Trump said. The remarks came at a time when New Delhi and Washington are working to deepen coopera-

tion on strategic and economic issues. AGENCIES

US, Iran

Iran’s President Masoud Pezeshkian told state TV they were ready “to assure the world that we are not after a nuclear weapon.” Iran’s embassy in India responded to Rubio on social media, saying Tehran has an “inalienable” right to nuclear technology. Iran has always insisted its program is peaceful while enriching uranium to near weapons-grade levels. Under the potential deal, Tehran would agree to give up its stockpile of highly enriched uranium, according to the two regional officials, who spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss the sensitive negotiations. One official, with direct knowledge of the negotiations, said that how Iran would give up the uranium would be subject to further talks during a 60-day period. Some would likely be diluted, while the rest would be transferred to a third country, the official said. Russia has offered to take it. Iran has 440.9 kilograms (972 pounds) of uranium that is enriched up to 60 per cent purity, a short, technical step from weapons-grade levels of 90 per cent, according to the International Atomic Energy Agency. Trump has sought greater concessions from Iran than those required under a 2015 Obama-era agreement that the US later withdrew from under Trump. On Saturday, Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesman Esmail Baghaei told the state-run news agency that there are “narrowing differences” between the Iranian and US positions, but that Iran is cautious after being attacked twice in the past year during nuclear negotiations. Pakistani army chief Asim Munir, a key mediator, left Tehran late Saturday after more talks with Iranian officials. Under the emerging agreement, the Strait of Hormuz would gradually reopen in parallel with the US ending its blockade, the officials said. The US would allow Iran to sell its oil through sanctions waivers, said the second official, who has been briefed on the negotiations. Sanctions relief and the release of Iran’s frozen funds

would be negotiated during the 60-day time frame, the official said. Both officials said the draft deal includes an end to the war between Israel and the Iran-backed Hezbollah militant group in Lebanon. Twelve weeks have passed since the US and Israel attacked Iran, killing its supreme leader and other top officials. A ceasefire with Iran has held since April 7, though the sides have exchanged fire on occasion. Several countries, including the European Union and the United Kingdom, welcomed progress on a possible deal with Iran. Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, in a social media post Sunday, said “President Trump and I agreed that any final agreement with Iran must eliminate the nuclear danger,” and that Trump had reaffirmed Israel’s right to defend itself “on every front, including Lebanon.” Science Minister Gila Gamliel, a member of Netanyahu’s Likud party and part of his national security cabinet, told Israel’s Army Radio that Israel is taking a “wait-and-see” approach. Israeli officials are concerned that Hezbollah remains a serious threat to Israel and that Lebanon is ill-equipped to disarm it. A fragile, US-brokered ceasefire took effect in Lebanon on April 17, but fighting has continued, mainly in the south. Hezbollah has launched daily drone and rocket attacks on Israeli forces and northern Israel, and Israel has struck targets across Lebanon while its troops remain in large swaths of the south. More than 3,000 people have been killed in the latest round of fighting, according to the Lebanese Health Ministry. Additionally, 22 Israeli soldiers and a defence contractor have been killed in or near southern Lebanon, and two civilians have been killed in northern Israel, according to Netanyahu’s office.

BJP sweeps

“I had appealed to voters to ensure a victory margin of one lakh votes. The lead has crossed that mark,” he said, while promising rapid development for the constituency. Prime Minister Narendra Modi too congratulated BJP can-

didate Debangshu Panda for the win. “Congratulations to Shri Debangshu Panda Ji for winning in Falta by a record margin. It indicates the unwavering faith of the people of West Bengal towards the BJP. People are seeing the exceptional work of the West Bengal Government across sectors and thus have decided to further bless us,” Modi wrote on X. “My compliments to all BJP Karyakartas across West Bengal for their outstanding work. We will keep working for West Bengal’s progress in the times to come,” he added. BJP candidate Debangshu Panda won the politically significant repoll by a margin of over one lakh votes. According to the final figures, Panda secured 149,666 votes, comfortably ahead of CPI(M) candidate Sambhu Nath Kurmi, who polled 40,645 votes. Congress nominee Abdur Razzak Molla stood third with 10,084 votes, while Trinamool Congress candidate Jahangir Khan slipped to fourth place with just 7,783 votes. The outcome marked a dramatic reversal from the 2021 Assembly election, when the TMC had comfortably retained the seat. In that election, TMC candidate Sankar Kumar Naskar had secured 1,17,179 votes against BJP candidate Bidhan Parui’s 76,805, winning by a margin of 40,374 votes. The constituency has an electorate of 2,36,768 voters. This time, the constituency had emerged as one of the state’s most closely watched battlegrounds after allegations of widespread irregularities during the April 29 polling. Complaints included the alleged use of perfume-like substances, suspicious ink marks and adhesive tapes on EVMs at several booths. Questions were also raised over alleged attempts to tamper with web-camera footage from polling stations. The Election Commission subsequently ordered repolling in all 285 booths under heavy deployment of nearly 35 companies of central forces. More than 87 per cent of the electorate cast their votes during the May 21 repoll. The scale of the BJP’s victory transformed the Falta repoll into a contest with implications far beyond South 24 Parganas, particularly as the constituency had long been projected by the TMC as a symbol of its organisational dominance in the Diamond Har-

bour belt. Adhikari accused the TMC of functioning like a “mafia company” dependent on extortion, syndicates and intimidation while in power. In a sharply worded statement, he alleged that the party had misused state machinery, looted public money and suppressed democratic voices over the years. Trinamool Congress national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee, however, questioned the credibility of the counting process and alleged large-scale irregularities. In a post on X, he claimed that all 21 rounds of counting in Falta were completed by 3.30 pm on Sunday, whereas during the May 4 counting process, only two to four rounds had been completed by that time. Alleging intimidation of TMC workers and vandalism of party offices during the Model Code period, Banerjee also claimed that counting agents of parties other than the BJP were forced out of the counting venue by officials and central forces. He demanded accountability from the Election Commission and called for an independent CCTV audit of the counting process, asserting that “questions over the credibility of the mandate will only grow stronger” unless a fair probe was conducted.

Bengal orders

issued on May 2, 2025, by the Foreigners Division of the Union Home Ministry regarding Bangladeshi and Rohingya immigrants. The advisory permits law enforcement agencies to detain individuals suspected of not being Indian citizens and keep them in holding centres for up to 30 days while their documents are verified. The final determination of citizenship status will be made by the district magistrate or an officer of equivalent rank. The state government said those identified as illegal immigrants would have their biometric data collected and uploaded to a central portal before being handed over to the Border Security Force for deportation. Such individuals would also be blacklisted from re-entering India. The BJP-led state government has adopted what it describes as a “detect, delete and deport” policy against illegal immigration. The Centre has also instructed states to form district-level special task

forces to identify and process suspected undocumented migrants. Officials said, in emergency situations, deportation could be carried out directly from the holding centres after verification procedures are completed. Recently, Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari had said: “By building strong coordination with the BSF, we will secure both the state and the nation. The previous government (Trinamool Congress) opposed providing protection under the CAA to refugees and failed to implement this crucial law.” Karnataka due to rains in the region. Officials said one or two people were initially swept away, prompting others to jump in to rescue them. Several were then caught in the fast-moving water. Ten bodies had been recovered by Sunday, while rescue teams, police personnel and local residents continued search operations for the two missing people. Eight of the deceased were identified as Umesh Manjunath Naik (40), Laxmi Mahadev Naik (42), Laxmi Jattappa Naik (30), Laxmi Appanna Naik (60), Laxmi Shivaram Naik (49), Jyoti Mastamma Naik (34), Malati Naik (38) and Mastamma Naik (60). The victims were all from Shirali. Two survivors, Nagaratna and Mahadevi, were rescued and admitted to hospital. President Droupadi Murmu described the incident as “very distressing” and offered condolences to the bereaved families while wishing the injured a quick recovery. Prime Minister Narendra Modi said he was deeply pained by the tragedy and announced an ex-gratia of Rs 2 lakh from the Prime Minister’s National Relief Fund for the families of each deceased victim and Rs 50,000 for the injured. Chief Minister Siddaramaiah announced Rs 5 lakh compensation for the next of kin of each victim, saying he was deeply distressed by the tragedy. Deputy Chief Minister D K Shivakumar and Leader of Opposition R Ashoka also mourned the deaths. Police said the exact sequence of events and whether all the victims knew swimming were still being examined.



QUEST FOR JUSTICE CONTINUES

‘Dowry’ case: Twisha Sharma cremated after 2nd autopsy in Bhopal

MPOST BUREAU

BHOPAL: The last rites of former actor-model Twisha Sharma, whose death has triggered nationwide outrage and allegations of dowry harassment, were performed in Bhopal on Sunday evening after a prolonged 12-day legal and emotional battle fought by her family in “pursuit of justice”.

Twisha’s younger brother, Major Harshit Sharma, lit the funeral pyre at Bhabhada Vishram Ghat as grieving family members and supporters bid farewell to the 33-year-old former Miss Pune. The cremation came hours after a second postmortem was conducted at AIIMS Bhopal by a specialised forensic team from AIIMS Delhi, following orders from the Madhya Pradesh High Court. Twisha was found hanging at her matrimonial home in Bhopal’s Katara Hills area on May 12. While her in-laws claimed she suffered from drug addiction, her family accused them of dowry harassment and abetment to suicide. The case gained national attention because Twisha’s husband, Samarth Singh, is a lawyer and her mother-in-law, Giribala Singh, is a retired district judge.

The second autopsy, which lasted nearly four hours, focused on preserving evidence and examining injuries that Twisha’s family alleged were overlooked during the first postmortem conducted locally. AIIMS Delhi’s Chief of Forensic Medicine, Dr Sudhir Gupta, said laboratory examinations, including histopathology and viscera analysis, would be required before the final report is prepared. The medical team also inspected



Harshit Sharma, brother of former model-turned-actor Twisha Sharma, performs rituals during the last rites of Twisha in Bhopal

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Twisha was found hanging at her matrimonial home in Bhopal on May 12
- » 2- While in-laws claimed she suffered from drug addiction, her family accused them of dowry harassment and abetment to suicide

Twisha’s residence and the alleged incident site as part of the investigation.

Twisha’s family had repeatedly demanded a fresh forensic examination, alleging procedural lapses in the initial probe. They claimed there were blunt force injuries on her left arm and forearm and sought detailed examination of the neck and cervical structures, toxicological analysis, and verification of whether injuries were consistent with hanging or any other possible cause of death. The Sharma family, originally from Noida, said the delay in the cremation forced them to violate tradi-

tional Hindu mourning practices, under which final rites are usually completed within 13 days of death. In an emotional statement, the family described the agony of waiting days before they could finally perform Twisha’s last rites. Twisha’s father, Navnidhi Sharma, struggled to speak while paying tribute to his daughter. “She cared for us like a mother. We don’t know how we will live without her. But we have hope because the Supreme Court has taken cognisance of the matter,” he said. Her mother, Rekha Sharma, broke down repeatedly during the cremation and had to be assisted by relatives and mourners. Major Harshit Sharma described his sister as loving, emotional and caring, comparing her to the “first ray of the rising sun.”

Amid mounting public pressure and protests outside Chief Minister Mohan Yadav’s residence, the Madhya Pradesh government recently assured the family that the case would be handed over to the CBI. Meanwhile, Samarth Singh was remanded to police custody by a Bhopal court on Saturday.

AMARAVATI: Andhra Pradesh Health minister Satya Kumar Yadav on Sunday said the state government is on high alert and has initiated precautionary measures in view of the spread of the Ebola virus and rising fatalities reported in parts of Africa. The minister said the precautionary measures include medical screening of passengers arriving from affected countries and strengthening emergency response systems to prevent any possible transmission in the state.

“The government is on high alert, necessary precautionary measures have been initiated, and the medical and health department is fully prepared to tackle any possible Ebola situation,” said Yadav in an official press release.

The minister noted that Ebola cases and deaths are being reported in the countries of the Democratic Republic of Congo, Uganda and South

PRECAUTIONS

- » Andhra Health minister Satya Kumar Yadav said the state govt has initiated precautionary measures in view of the spread of the Ebola virus and rising fatalities reported in parts of Africa
- » According to the minister, coordinated action has been initiated between airport authorities and district medical and health officials
- » ‘Individuals showing symptoms will be



immediately quarantined, while those who had close contact with suspected cases will also undergo medical screening’

Sudan and said that Andhra Pradesh is acting in line with advisories, guidelines and recommendations issued by the Centre and international health agencies.

According to the minister, coordinated action has been initiated between airport authorities and district medical and health officials to conduct screening of passengers and tourists arriving through international airports in Visakhapat-

nam, Tirupati and Vijayawada based on travel history. Individuals showing symptoms will be immediately quarantined, while those who had close contact with suspected cases will also undergo medical screening, he said. Yadav said discussions have also been held with Visakhapatnam Port authorities, and district administrations have been instructed to undertake preventive measures. He added that surveillance

would not remain limited to air routes, and necessary measures are being planned for people entering through road routes as well. The minister said the Central government is closely monitoring passengers arriving in India from Ebola-affected countries and sharing relevant information with states for necessary action. Drawing lessons from the Covid-19 period, he said the department is preparing an action plan focused

on precautionary measures and emergency response mechanisms.

Awareness and preparedness activities are also being strengthened through virtual meetings involving personnel from the Auxiliary Nurse Midwife (ANM) and Accredited Social Health Activist (ASHA) worker level onwards, said the minister. Dedicated isolation wards with 15 beds each are being readied at teaching hospitals located in cities with international airports to ensure immediate response capacity.

Yadav said districts are being kept alert through information shared by the Centre and added that PPE kits and virus diagnostic testing kits are sufficiently available.

Meanwhile, the minister urged people to avoid travel to D R Congo, Uganda and South Sudan unless necessary in line with the Central government advisories.

AGENCIES

SCREENING UNDERWAY AT AIRPORTS

Andhra govt on ‘high alert’ over Ebola virus

Kejriwal urges Centre to buy cheaper oil from Russia and Iran

NEW DELHI: Amid concerns over fuel shortages and growing distress among farmers, Aam Aadmi Party national convener Arvind Kejriwal on Sunday urged the Centre to procure cheaper oil and gas from Russia and Iran to provide relief from rising petrol, diesel and cooking gas prices.

Referring to reports from Gujarat, Kejriwal said farmers were facing severe difficulties in obtaining diesel, with long queues of tractors seen outside petrol pumps. He warned that a shortage of diesel would directly impact farming operations and worsen the challenges already confronting the agricultural sector.

Speaking to the media, the

AAP leader said he had seen reports on social media showing farmers waiting for hours for diesel supplies. “If farmers do not get diesel, how will they carry out farming?” he asked.

Kejriwal said that while fuel prices in the country had increased sharply, Russia and Iran were willing to supply oil and gas at cheaper rates. He questioned why the Government of India was not purchasing fuel from the two countries despite the possibility of reducing costs.

Appealing to the Centre to act quickly, Kejriwal urged the government to buy cheaper oil and gas so that people could get relief from fuel shortages and inflation.

MPOST

Woman walks 3 km carrying aged mother-in-law to bank for pension

AMBIKAPUR: A tribal woman walked nearly 3 km carrying her 90-year-old mother-in-law on her back to a bank to collect the latter’s Rs 500 monthly pension, pending for four months due to incomplete KYC (Know Your Customer) formalities, in Chhattisgarh’s Surguja district.

The incident took place in the Mainpat development block on Friday, and a video of the woman went viral on social media a day later.

In the video, the woman, identified as Sukhmaniya, who is in her late 50s, is seen walking along a road with her elderly mother-in-law on her back.

She told the person recording the video that earlier, a ‘Bank Mitra’ used to deliver the monthly pension of Rs 500 at her home, but she had not

The viral video from Chhattisgarh exposes insensitive formalities

received the pension for the last three to four months as the KYC process had not been completed.

Sukhmaniya, a resident of Jangalpara village in the Kunia area, travelled around 3 km to reach the Central Bank of India branch in Mainpat town on foot. Mainpat Janpad Panchayat Chief Executive Officer Khushboo Shastri said on Sunday that a Bank Mitra had earlier been visiting the woman’s house every month to deliver the pension amount.

“In January, the pension was delivered at her home for

the last time. The service was stopped over the past four months due to pending KYC formalities,” she said.

On May 22, Sukhmaniya reached the bank branch carrying her mother-in-law on her back without informing anyone. After the KYC formalities were completed at the branch, the bank immediately released the pending pension amount of Rs 2,000 for four months, she said.

The official said the Central Bank of India branch in Mainpat has seven Bank Mitras who deliver pension money at the doorstep of beneficiaries who are unable to visit the bank.

“From next month onwards, Sukhmaniya’s mother-in-law will again receive the pension amount at her home,” she added.

AGENCIES

Odisha: 4 dead after consuming food at ‘shraddha’

BHUBANESWAR/ROURKELA: Four persons died and over 20 others fell ill after allegedly consuming food at a ‘shraddha’ in Odisha’s Sundargarh district, officials said on Sunday.

The incident happened in Nuadihi village in Hemgir block of the district, they said. Soon after consuming the food, several people from Nuadihi village and neighbouring Sunakhaen village, which is in Jharsuguda district, complained of vomiting, stomach pain and severe weakness, they said. “The affected persons were rushed to nearby hospitals. Two women from Jharsuguda district and two others from Sundargarh district died during treatment.”

The deceased were identified as Mangal Sai Naik and Raibari Pradhan of Nuadihi village, and Ullas Khadia and Sukanti Khadia of Sunakhaen village, he said. Food poisoning is suspected to be the cause of the deaths, though the exact reason will be confirmed after medical examination and laboratory testing of food samples, officials said.

“After attending a funeral feast in Sundargarh district two days ago, some people developed diarrhoea-like symptoms. We have sent a medical team to the village, and food samples have been sent for laboratory testing,” Jharsuguda Collector Chavan Kunal Motiram said.

Sundargarh Chief District Medical Officer Suresh Chandra Mohanty said around 28 people fell sick from the suspected food poisoning. Of them, six were referred to a hospital in Sundargarh and one to VIMSAR, Burla.

Health minister Mukesh Mahaling expressed grief over the incident. “I am deeply saddened and heartbroken to learn about the deaths after consumption of food at a ‘shraddha’ in Nuadihi village under Hemgir block of Sundargarh district,” he said, wishing a speedy recovery to those undergoing treatment.

MPOST

Punjab: Mann confers Maharaja Ranjit Singh Award on 87 players

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Sunday conferred 87 players with the prestigious Maharaja Ranjit Singh Award and also honoured 1,070 medal-winning sportspersons from different disciplines.

The state government also distributed prize money worth Rs 32.05 crore among players through cheques.

Addressing a felicitation ceremony here, Mann said the day marked a historic moment for Punjab as 87 players were conferred with the prestigious Maharaja Ranjit Singh Award while 1,070 medal-winning sportspersons from different disciplines were also honoured.

“The Punjab government has not only honoured Olympic and Asian Games medalists with Rs 1 crore each but

The state govt also distributed prize money worth Rs 32.05 cr among players

has also provided jobs to nine medal-winning players,” he added.

“The players of Punjab have brought immense pride to the country and the state through their achievements on international platforms. It is our responsibility to stand firmly with them and ensure they receive the respect, recognition, and support they deserve,” he said.

Among the top honourees, Indian Women’s Cricket Team Captain Harmanpreet Kaur and all-rounder Amanjot Kaur

received Rs 1.50 crore each following their historic international cricket victories.

In shooting, world championship medalists Amanpreet Singh and Neeraj Kumar were awarded Rs 1.54 crore and Rs 1.52 crore respectively, while Kirandeep Kaur and Kritika Sharma received Rs 50 lakh each.

Rising shooter Vijayveer Sidhu was honoured with Rs 28.50 lakh, Wushu player Kushal Kumar received Rs 25 lakh, while para-powerlifting world champion Paramjit Kumar was awarded Rs 55 lakh for his remarkable international achievements.

Maharaja Ranjit Singh Awards were distributed across multiple yearly cycles to recognise consistent excellence in sports, he said.

MPOST

HP: Shimla ropeway project hits roadblock amid ‘cost escalations’

Cabinet rejects tender that could have helped project finally move forward

ASHWANI SHARMA

The ambitious Shimla Ropeway project, officially titled the “Rapid Ropeway Transport System” and backed by international agencies such as the New Development Bank (NDB), has suffered another setback. Conceived as a major solution to Shimla’s worsening vehicular congestion, the project has once again been delayed after the Himachal Pradesh cabinet decided to cancel the lone bid submitted for its execution.

The state Cabinet, which met two days ago, rejected the single tender that could have helped the long-pending project finally move forward. According to reports, Chief Minister Sukhwinder Singh Sukhu was not in favour of approving the bid because of the steep rise in the estimated cost of the project. While the ropeway was initially projected to cost Rs 1,734 crore, the latest bid reportedly raised the amount to nearly Rs 2,980 crore.

The proposed 13.79-km aerial transport system, planned

KEY POINTS

- » CM Sukhwinder Singh Sukhu was not in favour of approving the bid because of the steep rise in the estimated cost of the project
- » While the ropeway was initially projected to cost Rs 1,734 crore, the latest bid reportedly raised the amount to nearly Rs 2,980 crore

across 13 stations, has already received in-principle approval from both the Centre and the Himachal Pradesh government. The ropeway is designed as an eco-friendly transport network aimed at reducing traffic congestion, lowering emissions and cutting travel time for both residents and tourists in the hill town. According to the proposal, the ropeway will start near Taradevi and pass through key locations including Chakkar-Tutikandi Parking, Old Bus Stand, ISBT, 103 Tunnel,



» If commissioned, the project is expected to become the second-largest aerial transport system in the world

Victory Tunnel, Railway Station, Lift Point, Secretariat, Nav Bahar, Sanjauli, Indira Gandhi Medical College (IGMC) and the Ice Skating Rink.

If commissioned, the project is expected to become the second-largest aerial transport system in the world after the ropeway network in La Paz, Bolivia. Apart from easing traffic and parking problems, officials believe the project would significantly enhance Shimla’s profile as a major international tourist destination.

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Sunday announced a series of initiatives in honour of Maharishi Kashyap, including allotment of land for the construction of a dharamshala in Kaithal and installation of a grand statue at a chowk in Indri to be named after the revered sage. He also announced that adequate funds would be provided for establishing a Maharishi Kashyap Chair at Kurukshetra University.

The Chief Minister made these announcements while addressing a state-level function organised on the occasion of Maharishi Kashyap Jayanti at Sant Kabir Kutir in Chandigarh.

Paying tribute to Maharishi Kashyap, Saini described him as a great philanthropist and protector of society who



Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini addresses the gathering during a state-level function organised on the occasion of Maharishi Kashyap Jayanti at his residence in Chandigarh on Sunday

MPOST

guided people through scriptures such as the Kashyap Samhita and Smriti Granth. Highlighting the historical contribution of the Kashyap community, he said figures such as King Nishad during the Ramayana era and Bhakt

Kanpur hand amputation case to be reinvestigated

KANPUR: The Health department has ordered a fresh inquiry into the hand amputation case of Nirmala Devi, mother of an ITBP jawan, here following allegations that the earlier probe was biased. ITBP officers and police officials will now join the reinvestigation alongside the medical team.

Chief Medical Officer Dr Haridatt Nemi said the earlier report was prepared transparently and submitted to the police commissioner, but concerns raised by ITBP officials led to the decision for a fresh probe. Police Commissioner Raghuraj Lal has nominated an officer to assist in examining medical records, statements and findings.

The inquiry committee said the woman, a cardiac patient, suffered blockage in blood vessels that led to amputation. Histopathology tests are expected to determine the exact cause. CCTV footage from Krishna Hospital and Paras Hospital here is also being examined to trace treatment details and possible negligence during the critical 12-hour period.

MPOST

Nation Briefs

UP: 11-YEAR-OLD GIRL MAULED TO DEATH BY STRAY DOGS IN SHAHJAHANPUR

SHAHJAHANPUR: An 11-year-old girl was mauled to death by a pack of stray dogs in Shahjahanpur on Sunday morning while returning home from a vegetable field. The victim, Swalia, lived in the Kakrakalan locality. Her father, Naeem, a poor farmer who had leased farmland near the municipal corporation’s e-bus charging station, had taken her to the field around 10 am. He later asked her to return home and call her brother. While walking along a deserted stretch, Swalia was chased and attacked by stray dogs, which dragged her to the ground and inflicted severe injuries. Passersby rushed to help and took the girl to a hospital, where doctors declared her dead.

NFR GM INSPECTS ARARIA–GALGALIA SECTION’S ELECTRIFICATION

MALIGAON: Chetan Kumar Shrivastava, General Manager of Northeast Frontier Railway (NFR), carried out a comprehensive inspection of ongoing electrification works in the Araria–Galgolia section on May 22, along with a review of redevelopment and upgradation works at New Jalpaiguri (NJP) station. He was accompanied by senior officials from NFR Headquarters and Katihar Division during the inspection programme. During the visit, the GM inaugurated the newly developed Boot Laundry facility at Rautara under Katihar Division to enhance maintenance and cleaning arrangements of railway staff equipment and operational gear.



EDITORIAL

SKILLED EXODUS?

Trump's latest proposals around green cards and immigration have once again reignited anxiety among Indian professionals, students and visa holders in the United States. While immigration debates are hardly new in American politics, Trump's return to aggressive rhetoric on work visas, permanent residency pathways and "America First" employment policies signals a potentially difficult phase for one of the largest immigrant communities in the US. For Indians — who dominate high-skilled migration streams such as H-1B visas, STEM education and technology-sector employment — even policy uncertainty can have far-reaching consequences.

At the centre of the debate is the broader question of what America wants its immigration system to achieve. Trump and his political allies argue that green card allocations and work visas must prioritise American workers and reduce dependency on foreign labour. Supporters of tighter immigration rules believe that unrestricted inflows suppress wages, intensify labour competition and weaken domestic employment opportunities. But critics counter that the American economy, especially its technology, healthcare and research sectors, is deeply dependent on global talent. Any abrupt tightening of immigration pathways could therefore damage innovation, productivity and long-term economic competitiveness.

Indian professionals occupy a uniquely vulnerable position in this debate. Over the past two decades, Indian nationals have become the backbone of America's skilled immigration system. They account for a dominant share of H-1B visa holders and constitute one of the largest groups awaiting employment-based green cards. Thousands of Indian families remain trapped in decades-long green card backlogs because of per-country caps in the US immigration system. Many live in a state of prolonged uncertainty — legally employed, highly skilled, tax-paying residents, yet without the stability of permanent residency.

Trump's proposed tightening of green card norms, scrutiny of employer-sponsored immigration and emphasis on restricting migration pathways therefore strike directly at this community's aspirations. Even when policies are not immediately implemented, the climate of uncertainty affects career planning, investments, housing decisions and educational choices for migrant families. Visa holders become cautious about changing jobs, launching businesses or pursuing long-term commitments because their legal status remains tied to shifting political winds.

The implications extend beyond individuals. Indian students now represent one of the largest international student populations in the United States. For many, American education is not merely about acquiring a degree but about accessing a pathway to employment, residency and upward mobility. If immigration barriers harden further, students may increasingly reconsider whether the US remains the most attractive destination. Countries such as Canada, Australia and parts of Europe are already positioning themselves as more welcoming alternatives for skilled migrants.

At another level, the debate also exposes the contradictions within globalisation itself. The United States has long championed open markets, cross-border capital flows and global technological integration. Yet political resistance to labour mobility has steadily intensified. Highly skilled migrants are welcomed when economies require talent, but become politically contentious during periods of economic insecurity or nationalist mobilisation. Immigration thus becomes a symbolic battleground in larger anxieties about identity, jobs and economic control.

For India, these developments carry both risks and opportunities. A restrictive American immigration climate could disrupt remittance flows, reduce opportunities for Indian professionals abroad and create uncertainty for the vast ecosystem built around overseas education and migration. At the same time, it could also push India to confront an uncomfortable reality: the country cannot indefinitely rely on exporting talent while failing to generate enough high-quality opportunities at home.

India's long-term response cannot simply be diplomatic lobbying in Washington. It must involve creating stronger domestic research ecosystems, better universities, globally competitive technology sectors and more dignified employment opportunities for its educated youth. If India becomes capable of retaining talent through opportunity rather than compulsion, external immigration shocks will matter less.

America, meanwhile, faces its own strategic choice. Historically, its greatest strength has been its ability to attract and absorb global talent. Silicon Valley, American universities and major research institutions were built significantly through immigrant contributions. Policies driven excessively by political populism risk undermining this advantage.

The Trump-era immigration debate is therefore not merely about visas or green cards. It reflects a deeper struggle over the future of global mobility, economic nationalism and the meaning of opportunity in an interconnected world. For millions of Indian visa holders and aspiring migrants, the outcome will shape not only careers, but life trajectories itself.

IRON RESOLVE



ANIRBAN GANGULY

THE WRITER IS A MEMBER OF THE NATIONAL EXECUTIVE COMMITTEE (NEC), BJP, AND THE CHAIRMAN OF DR SYAMA PRASAD MOOKERJEE RESEARCH FOUNDATION

Poverty did not create Naxalism; Naxalism deepened poverty by blocking development, welfare and state presence

On May 19, 2026, Union Home Minister Amit Shah declared in Jagdalpur, Chhattisgarh, that Bastar had become Naxal-free. It was a historic declaration indicating the closure of one of the most debilitating and violent chapters in the history of independent India.

To the chagrin of Naxal drum-beaters, Urban-Naxals and Maoists sympathisers, the eradication of Naxalism-Maoism from India and a Naxal-free Bastar is one of the greatest national security achievements of the Narendra Modi government. It also comes across as the most decisive step forward in firming up India's internal security framework and sphere. The eradication and the blow are so clinical and all-encompassing that Naxals will never be able to regroup and revive. Urban Naxals are also tethering to their end, afflicted with acute depression; their only recourse is foreign pulpits and podiums where they can regurgitate their tired arguments of state repression under Modi. The world is not buying those arguments anymore.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah pointed out a hard truth when he said that these regions have suffered from neglect, poverty and backwardness for decades because of Naxalism and not the other way round. He had turned the spurious argument on its head. Speaking in the Lok Sabha in March 2026, Amit Shah argued that poverty spread because of Naxalism and not the other way round. Naxal sympathisers had long argued that the "root cause" of Naxalism was that these regions were backward. Shah argued that because these regions were allowed to become strongholds of Naxalism, they became backward.

The state, especially under the UPA, and the Congress, had abdicated its responsibility. It had withdrawn and surrendered these regions to this pernicious ideology. Shah pointed out how "earlier this area was under the shadow of the guns and bayonets" and how "the entire region remained deprived of development because of Naxalites. People here did not get ration cards, nor the benefit of free foodgrain schemes, nor health insurance of up to ₹5 lakh. Their produce was not procured at ₹3,100 per quintal. There was no trace of employment, electricity did not reach the villages, water did not reach, and schools were not built."

The development activists' cabal and the NGO ecosystem have never been able to effectively answer the question of why, even after decades of welfarism and India being a welfare state, these vast swathes of India saw no growth or prospects. Why haven't Naxal sympathisers such as Arundhati Roy, Binayak Sen, Harsh Mander, Aakar Patel, Medha Patkar, Prashant Bhushan, TM Krishna, Nikhil Dey, Arun Roy, Gautam Navlakha, Nivedita Menon, et al. never asked this basic question?

Amit Shah gave figures, and Urban Naxals haven't challenged these figures. He said, "We have completed the construction of 12,211 kilometres of roads at a cost of ₹20,557 crore. A total of 13,000 mobile tow-



PM Modi and Amit Shah's anti-Naxal campaign culminated in Bastar's transformation, marking a defining internal security achievement for the government

ers have been planned, out of which 5,000 towers have already been installed across Naxal-affected areas of the country. 1,804 bank branches have been opened, 1,321 ATMs have been installed, and the work of opening 890 post offices has also been completed. 259 Eklavya Model Schools have been opened, 46 ITIs and 49 Skill Development Centres have been established, and skill training has been provided to more than 90,000 youth and women."

Creative innovations saw the launching of the Bastar Pandum and the Bastar Olympics. Both are unique initiatives that have expedited the psychological rehabilitation of affected people in the region. The Bastar Pandum has become a major platform "for tribal dance, songs, language, traditional attire, cuisine, and other cultural elements", and 45,000 people have participated in it. The Bastar Olympics saw the participation of 3 lakh, 94 thousand athletes, which included a team of former Naxals who had been rehabilitated. This team performed best.

Why were these not done earlier, when the Congress-led UPA, with the self-professed pro-people NAC controlling the strings of policy formulation and cabinet decisions, was in power for an uninterrupted decade? Why did the Left, led by the CPM and the CPI, which propped the UPA and the Congress in power, not push for these developments? Their concerns for the backwards were tied to their ideological and political agendas. To let Bastar simmer in backwardness and under the grip of Naxalism suited their politics and its goal of keeping India internally on the boil.

A recent study by "The Indian Matrix" — "Reclaiming the Heartland: How State Capacity Defeated the Maoist Insurgency", clearly brings out how the Indian state, under the Modi decade, had effectively asserted itself to make India Naxal-free. An act that the UPA decades had repeatedly shunned.

For over 5 decades, the report notes, "the Indian State ceded" its monopoly, its duty in its "central heartland", creating a vacuum in which "a parallel sovereign collected taxes, administered justice and

waged war." The UPA was accommodating to Naxals, allowing its expansion, both ideologically and physically.

Let us recall the peculiar phenomenon where the Congress Home Minister P Chidambaram advocated a hardline against Naxalism, while his own party men and allies opposed it publicly and stalled it in the cabinet. In its strategic push to dismantle the Maoist-Naxal stranglehold, when Union Home Minister Amit Shah strongly advocated and pushed for establishing "permanent Forward Operating Bases (FOBs) deep inside Maoist core territories, including the Abhujad region in Chhattisgarh", one could not help but remember how the Congress-Sonia-NAC leadership had stymied P Chidambaram's efforts to set up these FOBs in the past. Chidambaram may deny it. But it was public knowledge how he was then ideologically assailed by his party and NAC members. For BJP ministers Rajnath Singh and, later, Amit Shah, there was no such ideological hesitation, confusion or constraints. The clear goal that PM Modi set was that of a Naxal-free India.

The Congress-UPA was apologetic, accommodative, the report says, "prioritising talks and downplaying threats". The report makes an interesting observation: it argues, "When the State's posture is ambiguous, the local population hedges its bets, often sheltering insurgents for survival", and when the "State's posture is absolute, the insurgency's civilian support structure evaporates." PM Modi's government's relentlessness in wiping away the threat of Naxalism made this civilian support structure eventually evaporate.

The 2004-2013 years were the "Apologetic and Reluctant Era." The report reminds us of how, throughout these years, the state suffered from a "profound policy paralysis." The NAC members, many of whom "harboured deep sympathies for the Maoist cause" spoke of Naxals and Maoists as "our misguided children."

High-profile activists such as Arundhati Roy termed the Maoists as "Gandhis with Guns" and justified their terror and violence. This encouraged and incu-

lated ideological ambivalence in the UPA dispensation. This ideological ambivalence disappeared post-2014, with the Modi dispensation.

2019 to 2023 saw a systematic push to dismantle the Naxal support structure. The sources of financial oxygen for the Maoists-Naxals were struck. The Indian Matrix report notes that "by aggressively hardening the Foreign Contribution Regulation Act (FCRA), the State choked the flow of international funding to NGOs and front organisations that subtly funnelled resources to the Maoist ecosystem." The Urban-Naxal network that extended ideological and legal cover to the armed cadres was also systematically exposed.

The approach was not surgical alone; it was also incentive-based. It also focused on surrender and rehabilitation. The Indian Matrix report observes how the "Niyad Nellanar" (Your Good Village) scheme, launched in 2024 in Chhattisgarh, was effective. It "mandated saturating a 5-kilometre radius around every new security camp with schools, roads, and healthcare." The ultimatum to the armed cadre was unambiguous: "surrender or die." Those who surrendered, the report observes, "were met with comprehensive rehabilitation policies and livelihood skilling. Those who didn't aren't around to tell the tale." Let us recall that between 2016 and 2025, over 8,000 surrenders had taken place. It pointed to a complete ideological and infrastructure collapse among the Naxals.

2024-2026, the push entered its final phase with intellectual and financial lines choked, and the complete "decapitation of the top leadership." All this while the Congress and the Communists cried, calling for being accommodative and for talks. Amit Shah was assertive in his stance when he told the Lok Sabha in March 2026 that talks should not be held with those who carry and wield the gun. "Give up arms, and talks will follow."

Between 2024 and 2026, the Indian Matrix report records, "the most feared commanders of the PLGA were wiped out." Among those neutralised was Madvi Hidma, the mastermind of the 2010 Dhantewada and 2021 Sukma attacks. While Hidma's ideological comrades mourned, the Indian Republic heaved a sigh of relief. The "ideological and operational core" had been systematically decimated.

The era of the apologetic state was over, the "eradication era" of 2024-2026 was triumphant, and the "Indian Republic systematically dismantled the largest internal security threat in its history." Naxal-free India became one of PM Modi's biggest achievements. Amit Shah, as Union Home Minister, had kept his promise. Naxalism, which was once justified by a large section of the Congress and the Left as a way of life, an ideology that one could do business and live with, was obliterated. While Naxal sympathisers, the real traitors, mourned, the Indian Republic breathes and lives in a new dawn.

Views expressed are personal

Naxal-Free Bharat

The Modi government's relentless campaign against Naxalism has reshaped Bastar from a conflict zone into a symbol of restored peace

ENERGY SHIFT



SUNITA NARAIN

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The challenge is no longer about adding green power, but about planning an energy mix that can be fitted and flexed

It is a time of great energy disruption. This is now well understood. The question I asked previously is if this oil shock—caused by the US-Israel war against Iran—will disrupt the ongoing energy transition where, gradually but surely, renewable energy is making inroads into electricity generation across the world. Solar and wind energy, which were nascent and untested technologies during the oil shock of the 1970s, have now demonstrated that they can work at scale. The question now is how the world will evolve around the issues of energy security and rebuilding confidence in supply chains. This is where the new energy map will be drawn—between the old and new countries that supply fossil fuels, and China as the powerhouse of new green technology.

This time, I want to discuss India's energy options going forward. What is clear is that the Indian government's strategy of displacing, and not replacing, coal is within reach. But challenges remain, and this must be the centre of our future focus.

It is no longer a question of whether India's energy planning should, or can, incorporate new green technologies like solar or wind. The question is how these technologies will fit into the grid so that supply is reliable. These energy technologies, unlike the conventional fossil fuel-driven power stations, are intermittent—they supply electricity only when the wind is blowing, or the sun is shining. Therefore, the challenge is how to store the power generated during these hours, or how to integrate these intermittent energy systems with electricity generated from coal or gas, hydropower and even nuclear power.



Countries must deepen their ability to manufacture green technologies and secure vital components and build confidence in the new supply chains

The picture becomes clearer when you consider recent events. April 25, 2026, was a particularly hot day across different regions of the country. It was a sizzler, and power demand spiked as everyone cranked up their fans and air conditioners to stay cool. Electricity demand reached an all-time high, touching 256 GW—and what was incredible was that at its peak supply, renewable energy had kicked in. Solar supplied some 24 per cent, and non-fossil added up to 30 per cent.

But, as my colleagues point out in their detailed analysis of this new power day, this is only half the story. During the solar energy peak of the day, coal power flexed to its technical limit of 55 per cent—coal plants are designed for certain operational limits and cannot go below this, unless rede-

signed for flexibility. At night, when the sun was not shining, coal kicked back in to meet 78-82 per cent of the electricity.

This is where the rubber meets the road: how will the grid meet demand during non-solar hours; how will coal power plants operate or not during this period? The way ahead, most logically, say my colleagues, is to redesign coal plants for "flexibility"—to operate at lower capacities. It is also about careful grid planning so that more coal-powered plants do not get built, which then have the same problem of being inflexible to fit into intermittent renewable energy. It is about planning an energy mix, which can be fitted and flexed. So, for instance, hydropower or even gas-based turbines are easier to switch on and off, as compared to coal power.

There is, of course, the other part of this solution, to build storage for the generated electricity during the day to be used at night. This can be done at the power plant or the utility or at households. The core of this option will be the cost of the storage battery if countries have the capacity to manufacture it.

All this brings us back to the question of confidence in energy supply chains. The difference between oil and gas supply chains and those for renewable energy lies not only in geography and geopolitics but also in the fact that oil and gas requires flow to be assured while renewable technology is about purchasing the stock. In other words, once a country secures its solar power infrastructure, it no longer depends on a regular supply, as in the case of oil or gas.

But this is not so easy. Countries must deepen their ability to manufacture green technologies and secure vital components and build confidence in the new supply chains. For instance, the Society for Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM) has reportedly objected to the Delhi government proposal to mandate the sale of only electric two-wheelers from April 2028, saying that this would increase dependence on China for battery imports and heavy rare-earth magnets. If this argument is accepted, it would derail India's transition to cleaner vehicles and cleaner air.

The future of energy will be about finding answers to these questions, not about digging for more coal or oil. It is no longer about the reliability of old technologies—the conventional coal- or gas-based power plants or internal combustion engine vehicles—but about finding order in great disorder.

Views expressed are personal

BANNED OUTFIT BLA CLAIMS RESPONSIBILITY

Suicide car bomb attack on train in Pak kills at least 24

KARACHI: At least 24 people were killed and dozens injured when a powerful explosion ripped through a shuttle train in Pakistan's Balochistan province on Sunday, officials said.

The banned Baloch Liberation Army (BLA) has claimed responsibility for the blast in Quetta, the capital city of Balochistan province.

The shuttle train was heading from Quetta Cantonment to the city railway station when it was targeted near Chaman Phatak, the state-run Associated Press of Pakistan (APP) said.

When contacted, a senior police official put the death toll at 24 but didn't rule out a further increase in the toll. "The explosion was very powerful when it hit the moving shuttle train," he said.

At least two doctors at two separate hospitals in Quetta, where the dead bodies and injured were taken, confirmed that 20 bodies were in the mortuary.

"I can't say anything officially but we have 20 bodies at the Civil Hospital and Bolan Medical College Hospital," one of the doctors, who didn't want to be named, said.

Both doctors confirmed that over 50 persons, including women and children, were under treatment at the two hospitals.

They also said some bodies and a few injured were also taken to the Quetta district



Security officials remove damaged train coaches with the help of a crane at explosion site, in Quetta on Sunday AP/PTI

hospital.

A BLA spokesperson said the attack was carried out as the train was transporting military personnel from the cantonment area.

Shahid Rind, spokesperson for the Balochistan provincial government, confirmed the death toll had increased from his previous briefing when he put the figure at 14.

"We will be giving another media briefing soon, but I can say casualties have increased," Rind said on telephone.

Earlier the government said the dead included three persons of the Frontier Corps.

Pakistan's Railways Minister Hanif Abbasi has said there were civilian passengers in the

Highlights

- » The shuttle train was heading from Quetta Cantonment to the railway station in city
- » The region has witnessed a few such incidents in the past several years
- » The incident took place ahead of Eid festival

shuttle train, and the explosion hit the engine and three coaches.

Television channels showed eyewitnesses claiming that they saw an explosive-laden minivan slam into the shuttle train ahead of the blast.

The intensity of the explosion shattered the windshields of nearby vehicles and the window panes of nearby buildings.

A large number of train passengers were people looking forward to catching connecting trains to their home stations for the upcoming Eid festival, officials said.

Revellers pack Hong Kong island for bun festival

HONG KONG: Hong Kong's iconic bun festival drew throngs of revelers to the densely populated city's outlying island, Cheung Chau, to celebrate a century-old tradition that is rooted in prayers for peace and blessings.

Residents and tourists braved the heat to watch children in costumes take part in a parade, called "Piu Sik," which translates as "floating colours."

Children dressed as legendary deities, historic characters or local politicians were carried on stands above the crowds, moving through the island's narrow lanes.

Suspect killed after opening fire on Secret Service near White House

WASHINGTON: A man who opened fire Saturday near a White House security checkpoint is dead after being shot by officers who returned fire, the US Secret Service said. It was the third incidence of gunfire in the vicinity of President Donald Trump in the past month.

The law enforcement agency said in a statement posted on X that the man was in the area of 17th Street and Pennsylvania Avenue when he "pulled a weapon from his bag" shortly after 6 p.m. EDT and began firing.

Secret Service officers returned fire and hit the suspect, who died at a hospital, the agency said.

The suspect was identified as 21-year-old Nasire Best

The suspect was identified as 21-year-old Nasire Best, said a law enforcement official who spoke on the condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to discuss the investigation.

According to District of Columbia court records, Best was arrested in July 2025 after he attempted to enter a different White House checkpoint without authorization, didn't heed officers' commands to stop, "claimed he was Jesus Christ" and said he wanted to be arrested.

An initial hearing was held and a "Pretrial Stay Away Order" was issued, typically a measure ordering a defendant not to go near a person or area before a trial.

A bench warrant was issued in August after a notice of "noncompliance" against Best, who did appear for a subsequent hearing.

It was the third time in the past month that shots were fired near the president after incidents at the White House Correspondents' Association Dinner in April and near the Washington Monument earlier in May.

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Security forces kill around 27 TTP terrorists in Pak

PESHAWAR: Pakistani security forces killed 27 terrorists belonging to the banned TTP in multiple operations over the weekend in the country's northwest, officials said on Sunday.

The security forces conducted intelligence-based operations in the North Waziristan and Bannu districts of the restive Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province.

Several terrorist locations were targeted during the operations in the Datta Khel area of the North = Waziristan district, according to a statement issued by the Inter-Services Public Relations (ISPR) - the media wing of the Pakistan Army.

'Pak hopes to host next round of Iran-US talks very soon'

ISLAMABAD: Pakistan's Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif on Sunday said that Islamabad hopes to host the next round of peace talks between Tehran and Washington very soon.

He praised US President Donald Trump for "his extraordinary efforts to pursue peace" in West Asia, while he committed that Pakistan will continue efforts for peace in the region.

Trump, on Saturday, held a phone call with the leaders of Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Turkey, Egypt, the United Arab Emirates, Jordan, Bahrain and Pakistan. For Pakistan, it was Army chief Field Marshal Asim Munir who was on the call, said Sharif.

Sharif, who is currently on a visit to China, also praised the field marshal, saying: "I greatly



Pakistan's Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif

appreciate his tireless efforts during the entire process.

The Pakistan PM said in a statement on X: "The discussions provided a useful opportunity to exchange views on the current regional situation and how to move the ongoing peace efforts forward to bring lasting peace in the region. Pakistan will continue its peace

efforts with utmost sincerity and we hope to host the next round of talks very soon."

Munir was in Tehran till late Saturday evening, holding talks with top Iranian leaders on accelerating efforts to achieve a "conclusive agreement" between the US and Iran to bring peace in West Asia.

As Munir wrapped up his trip, Trump said in a statement on Truth Social: "An agreement has been largely negotiated, subject to finalisation between the United States of America, the Islamic Republic of Iran, and the various other countries."

Trump also said that he had a separate phone call with Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu "which, likewise, went very well".

WHILE WAITING FOR A PEACE DEAL

Britain's navy prepares to clear mines in Hormuz

ABOARD THE RFA LYME BAY: Aboard the RFA Lyme Bay docked off the coast of Gibraltar, hundreds of British sailors are waiting to be deployed for a mine-clearing mission to the Strait of Hormuz that is still in doubt.

US President Donald Trump has lashed out at allies for not doing more to support the United States' war effort in Iran, whose chokehold on the strait has crippled international shipping and sent energy prices soaring. In March, Trump told NATO allies to "go get your own oil" and secure the strait themselves.



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

On the southern tip of the Iberian Peninsula, in the British Overseas Territory of Gibraltar, the UK's Royal Navy is preparing to do that — but only once a peace agreement is reached.

Trump said Saturday that

a deal with Iran has been "largely negotiated" after calls with Israel and other allies in the region, but it still needs finalising.

Britain's Armed Forces Minister Al Carns took a small group of reporters to visit the RFA Lyme Bay as it prepares for a possible international operation, led by the UK and France, to secure the strait.

As Carns spoke, the amphibious landing vessel, docked at the gateway to the Mediterranean, was being loaded with ammunition and mine-hunting sea drones

equipped with sonar.

With a crew of several hundred sailors, the RFA Lyme Bay will soon depart Gibraltar to link up with the UK destroyer HMS Dragon and allied ships for air support before sailing through the Suez Canal to the Persian Gulf.

"Which other country can pull together 40 nations and come up with a solution to deal with a complex problem that we couldn't predict because we weren't involved?" asked Carns, responding to a question from The Associated Press about what Trump wants from his British ally.

Russia uses hypersonic Oreshnik missile in mass attack on Kyiv

KYIV: Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Sunday that Russia used the powerful hypersonic Oreshnik ballistic missile during a mass drone and missile attack on Kyiv on Sunday that killed at least two people, marking the third time the weapon has been used in the four-year war.

The intense aerial assault damaged buildings across the Ukrainian capital, including near government offices, residential buildings, schools and a market, Ukrainian authorities said. At least 83 people were wounded in the attack.

Air raid sirens blared through the night as smoke billowed across the city from strikes. Associated Press reporters heard powerful



Firefighters put out the fire at a prayer house of a local Protestant community of Evangelical Christian Baptists following Russian air attack in Balakliia on Saturday AP/PTI

explosions near the city centre and close to government buildings.

The attack included 600 strike drones and 90 air, sea

and ground-launched missiles, according to Ukraine's Air Force. Ukrainian air defences destroyed and jammed 549 drones and 55 missiles.

Mine blasts kill 3 B'deshis along Myanmar border

DHAKA: Landmine explosions along Bangladesh's south-eastern frontier with Myanmar on Sunday killed three villagers working on their plantations.

The incident sparked panic in the troubled border areas amid the grinding civil war in Myanmar, expanding its blow in the neighbouring country.

"Our initial reports suggest the landmines exploded near the no-man's-land area at Gumdhum neighbourhood along the Bangladesh-Myanmar borders," executive chief or Upazila Nirbahi Officer (UNO) Enamul Hasan of Naikhongchhari sub-district told reporters.

Paramilitary Border Guard Bangladesh (BGB) commander in the area Lieutenant Colonel Khairul Alam said the explosions severely wounded the three Bangladeshi tribesmen, who were declared dead after locals rushed them to a hospital. Alam said without immediate elaboration that the mines had exploded this afternoon near border pillar number 42 at the Gumdhum area.

Residents, including local journalists, said the men belonging to the Tanchanga ethnic minority community were injured in three subsequent blasts as they were working on their horticulture plantations.

China probes causes after 82 killed in coal mine blast



Rescue workers pass by an ambulance in the aftermath of an explosion at Changzhi city's Liushenyu coal mine in Qinyuan county AP/PTI

QINYUAN: Authorities in northern China were investigating a coal mine operator with a focus on safety lapses, as rescuers searched for those missing in the country's deadliest coal mine explosion in recent years that killed at least 82 people.

An Associated Press reporter witnessed police and security guarding the entrance to the mining facility located in Qinyuan county in the city of Changzhi as emergency vehicles were on site.

Hundreds of emergency responders and medical personnel were sent to help with rescue efforts, state media reported. Rescuers were taking turns to go down the mine shaft, according to the official Xinhua News Agency, facing hurdles including flooded tunnels.

Chinese President Xi Jinping called for a thorough investigation and accountability of those responsible follow-

ing the explosion on Friday evening at the Liushenyu coal mine in the northern province of Shanxi.

Two were missing, and dozens of miners were hospitalised, local officials said late Saturday. The death toll was revised down from 90, with officials blaming "chaotic" scenes in the aftermath and inaccurate information provided by the mine operator as a reason.

Some hospitalised miners recalled seeing smoke and blacking out, according to state media reports. Many among the injured were hurt by toxic gas.

The inland Shanxi province, located southwest of Beijing with a population of around 34 million, is China's main coal-mining area. A few hundred meters (yards) from the mine lies the village of Shangzhuang, where some of the miners who work at the site live, including some of the victims, residents said.

Republicans are rushing to redraw districts before midterms

WASHINGTON: Republicans are rushing to redraw congressional districts to their advantage ahead of the midterm elections following a recent US Supreme Court decision that weakened minority protections under the federal Voting Rights Act.

In a matter of just weeks, new US House districts already have been enacted in Tennessee and Alabama and have cleared at least one legislative chamber in Louisiana and South Carolina. But hurdles remain in

courthouses and capitols before the new maps can be used in the November elections.

Voting districts typically are redrawn after a census at the start of a decade. But President Donald Trump has urged Republican-led states to redistrict now to try to hold on to the GOP's narrow House majority in the face of political headwinds.

A president's party typically loses congressional seats in the midterms, and Trump's approval ratings are in the

negative.

Republicans stand to gain seats from the aggressive redistricting.

Since Trump first urged Texas to redraw its voting districts last year, Republicans think they could win as many as 15 additional seats from new House districts in seven states. Democrats have countered only partially, hoping to pick up six seats from new districts in two states.

Here's a look at where things stand on the most recent

redistricting efforts:

Republican Governor Henry McMaster called lawmakers into special session to consider congressional redistricting. The Republican-led House passed a plan early Wednesday that would improve the party's chances of winning the state's only Democratic-held seat.

Senators met for the third straight day Saturday to consider the redistricting plan, then set up a possible final vote Tuesday after what could be a

dozen hours of debate.

But passage is not guaranteed.

Early primary voting starts that same day, and opponents hope that puts pressure on redistricting supporters because thousands of voters could cast ballots for congressional candidates that may not be counted.

"These votes on Tuesday matter more than they ever have before," Democratic Senator Jeffrey Graham said.

China sends astronaut on year-long space mission as it eyes 2030 moon landing

Chinese astronauts have carried out multiple missions to Tiangong space station

JIUQUAN: China launched the Shenzhou 23 spacecraft Sunday night with three astronauts heading to its space station, including one set to stay in space for a year.

The spacecraft blasted off from the Jiuquan Satellite Launch Centre in northwest China.

The much-anticipated launch comes as China prepares for its first crewed lunar landing by 2030. The astronauts on the mission are Zhu Yangzhu, the commander, Zhang Zhiyuan and Lai Ka-ying, also identified by Chinese authorities as Li Jiaying, using the Mandarin transliteration of her name.

Lai, who was born and raised in Hong Kong and has a doctoral degree in computer forensics, is the first astronaut from the city on a space mission. The crew is set to conduct



The Shenzhou-23 manned mission launches from the Jiuquan Satellite Launch Center in Jiuquan on Sunday AP/PTI

dozens of science and application projects, state media said. They are also expected to complete an in-orbit rotation with the crew of Shenzhou 21, who have been at the Tiangong space station for more than 200 days.

One of the three astronauts

on the Shenzhou 23 mission is scheduled to stay at the orbiting space station for a year in what would be among the world's longest single stays in space.

The astronaut's mission is to "explore human adaptability and performance limits" in long-duration spaceflight

The US is seen as China's top space rival, with NASA aiming to land astronauts on the lunar surface in 2028

environments, state media reported.

As China steps up its space program, its astronauts have carried out multiple missions to the Tiangong space station, developed after China was effectively excluded from the International Space Station due to US concerns over national security. The US is seen as China's top space rival, with NASA aiming to land astronauts on the lunar surface in 2028.

World Briefs

SYRIA HOLDS LEGISLATIVE ELECTIONS IN KURDISH-MAJORITY NORTHEAST

HASSAKEH: Syria held follow-up parliamentary elections on Sunday in the Kurdish-majority northeastern province of Hassakeh and the town of Kobani, areas that were reintegrated under government control after fighting in January. Other parts of Syria voted for the People's Assembly last October, almost a year after the Assad dynasty was ousted in a rebel offensive. However, at that point, large swaths of the country's northeastern region were still under the control of the Kurdish-led Syrian Democratic Forces, notably Hassakeh and Kobani.

THOUSANDS IN SPAIN'S CAPITAL PROTEST INCREASING HOUSING COSTS

MADRID: Thousands of people rallied in central Madrid on Sunday against spiralling housing costs that have priced many Spaniards out of the housing market despite a recent economic boom, particularly in cities such as the capital and Barcelona. Spain's housing crisis is one of Socialist Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez's main political vulnerabilities before elections in 2027. The country has a strong tradition of home ownership.

EXECUTION STRENGTH REMAINS INTACT

Adani overhang easing after US developments, says Bernstein

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Brokerage firm Bernstein said concerns surrounding the Adani Group following the 2023 short-seller episode and subsequent US regulatory developments now appear largely behind the group, potentially paving the way for a revival in foreign funding and broader investor participation.

In a report covering four listed Adani companies - Adani Ports & SEZ, Adani Green Energy, Adani Power and Ambuja Cements - Bernstein said many global funds had stayed away from the group pending clarity on US-related developments, leaving several stocks under-owned despite strong operational execution.

The report said the settlement of the US SEC case and moves by US prosecutors to drop charges against the group had removed a major overhang on Adani stocks, many of which still trade below pre-crisis levels despite a sharp recovery.

"The group has gone through two big events in the last 4 years - the short seller event in January 2023 and US SEC-DoJ related developments starting November 2024. With the latest news from the US, both seem to be behind," it said.

The group is highly debated - many funds stayed away till clarity on the US developments



'The settlement of the US SEC case and moves by US prosecutors to drop charges against the group had removed a major overhang on Adani stocks'

Highlights

- » 'The group has gone through two big events in the last 4 years - short seller event in January 2023 & US SEC-DoJ related developments starting Nov 2024'
- » The brokerage said the group's core strength remained its ability to execute large-scale infra projects efficiently
- » The report said concerns over promoter share pledges had eased significantly

cence, and most stocks are still under-owned. "What was never debated though is their execution prowess (except in cement), and how important they are to build Infra in India."

The Adani Group had come under intense scrutiny in January 2023 after US-based short seller Hindenburg Research alleged stock manipulation, improper use of offshore tax havens and accounting irregularities across group companies.

While the ports-to-energy conglomerate repeatedly denied the allegations, calling them baseless and malicious, the report triggered a sharp selloff

in Adani stocks, wiped out billions of dollars in market value and led to heightened concerns over leverage and corporate governance.

However, most Adani stocks subsequently recovered part of their losses as the group cut promoter share pledges, reduced debt concerns and restored investor confidence through continued operational growth. SEBI told the Supreme Court of India that it had completed most of its probes and found no evidence warranting cancellation of licenses or broader market intervention, while a limited number of investiga-

tions remained ongoing. Hindenburg later ceased operations and is no longer active.

Separately, in November 2024, US authorities, including the US Department of Justice and the US Securities and Exchange Commission, initiated proceedings linked to alleged disclosures and fundraising practices involving Adani entities.

However, earlier this month a settlement was reached on the SEC-related matter and US prosecutors moved to drop charges against the group, having eased a major overhang on the conglomerate and improved prospects for renewed foreign investor participation and dollar funding access.

The brokerage said the group's core strength remained its ability to execute large-scale infrastructure projects efficiently and gain market share from state-run incumbents across sectors such as ports, logistics, thermal power and renewables.

Bernstein highlighted the group's access to large contiguous land parcels, execution speed and operational scale as key competitive advantages, noting that Adani-controlled assets now account for around 50 per cent of India's container port market. The report said concerns over promoter share pledges, a major issue during

the January 2023 short-seller crisis, had eased significantly, with pledged shares across group firms declining sharply since 2022.

While net group debt has increased by roughly Rs 1 trillion since September 2024 due to aggressive capital expenditure-led growth, Bernstein said earnings growth remained strong, with group EBITDA rising at a compound annual growth rate of 22 per cent between FY23 and FY26.

The group's net debt-to-EBITDA ratio, which had fallen to 2.7 times during the US-related developments, had risen again to 3.9 times by March 2026, though it remained below levels seen during the short-seller episode.

Bernstein added that the Adani Group had significantly diversified its funding profile over the years, reducing dependence on domestic banks while increasing bond financing. It said access to dollar funding, which had slowed following the regulatory overhang, could improve again after recent developments in the US.

The report said debt repayment schedules, particularly at Adani Green, appeared manageable with no significant near-term maturities, while bond yields had eased and were now below Indian five-year government bond yields.

LIC tops profit chart among Indian financial cos in Q4 FY26

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: State-owned Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) has emerged as the highest profit-making firm in the Indian financial sector in the March quarter, netting a little over Rs 23,400 crore.

Even among Central Public Sector Enterprises, the Corporation maintained the number one position for fourth-quarter profit for FY26.

Last week, LIC reported a 23 per cent jump in net profit to record Rs 23,420 crore in the just concluded March quarter as compared to Rs 19,013 crore in the corresponding period of the previous year.

The insurance behemoth was followed by the country's biggest lender State Bank of India (SBI), and the second-biggest lender HDFC Bank with profit of Rs 19,684 crore and Rs 19,221 crore, respectively, during the fourth quarter, according to the financial numbers posted on exchanges.

However, SBI significantly outpaced LIC in annual profit, earning Rs 80,032 crore in FY26 compared to LIC's Rs 57,419 crore.

Similarly, HDFC Bank's profit stood at Rs 74,670 crore while ICICI Bank posted a profit of Rs 50,147 crore.

Among other PSUs, Indian Oil Corporation (IOC) closed the fourth quarter with a net profit of Rs 11,378 crore followed by Coal India at Rs 10,839 crore, Power Finance Corporation (PFC) earned



LIC reported a 23% rise in net profit to record Rs 23,420 crore in Q4 FY26 against Rs 19,013 crore in corresponding period of previous year

Rs 8,598 crore and NTPC Rs 8,747 crore as profit, as per the data available on stock exchanges.

Other Central Public Sector Enterprises (CPSEs) like Power Grid Corporation of India posted a profit of Rs 4,546 crore, REC Ltd net profit at Rs 3,375 crore, and Steel Authority of India Ltd at Rs 1,680 crore.

A day after the stellar performance of LIC, its shares jumped 5 per cent in opening trade at Rs 839 apiece on the BSE on May 23.

LIC's Assets Under Management (AUM) increased to Rs 57,29,396 crore as of March 31, 2026, from Rs 54,52,297 crore on March 31, 2025, registering an increase of 5 per cent year-on-year.

Key Points

- » LIC was followed by SBI & HDFC Bank with profit of Rs 19,684 crore and Rs 19,221 crore, respectively
- » However, SBI significantly outpaced LIC in annual profit, earning Rs 80,032 crore in FY26 against LIC's Rs 57,419 crore
- » LIC's AUM rose to Rs 57,29,396 crore as of March 31, 2026, from Rs 54,52,297 crore on March 31, 2025, an increase of 5 per cent year-on-year

During the year, LIC's total premium income rose by 10 per cent to Rs 54,52,297 crore compared to Rs 54,52,297 crore a year ago. At the same time, adjusted net worth improved to Rs 1,69,605 crore from Rs 1,20,258 crore in FY25.

Among the entire corporate sector, Vodafone Idea became the highest quarterly profit earner in the January-March quarter with a record bottomline of Rs 51,970 crore, its first ever in about six years mainly due to relief in statutory liabilities.

It was followed by Reliance Industries with a net profit of Rs 16,971 crore, down from Rs 19,407 crore in the same January-March period in the preceding year.

Govt expands fuel dispenser checks to cover hydrogen and clean fuels

NEW DELHI: The consumer affairs ministry has amended legal metrology rules to allow government-approved testing centres to verify hydrogen, LPG, LNG and CNG fuel dispensers, expanding the country's measurement oversight framework as cleaner fuel adoption grows.

The Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution amended the Legal Metrology (Government Approved Test Centre) Rules, 2013, bringing the total number of instrument categories verifiable through Government Approved Test Centres (GATCs) to 23 from 18.

Verification fees for petrol and diesel dispensers have been set at Rs 5,000 per nozzle, while CNG, LPG, LNG and hydrogen dispensers will attract a higher fee of Rs 10,000



per nozzle.

"The move is expected to enhance the availability of verification services, improve efficiency and support the growing adoption of cleaner fuels across the country," the ministry said in a statement.

GATCs are approved private facilities with the technical expertise to carry out verification and re-verification of specified weights and measures under the Legal Metrology Act. The framework allows

qualified private laboratories to expand national verification capacity beyond state government resources.

Under the amended rules, state governments will be empowered to notify additional categories of instruments for GATC verification based on local requirements. Officers of the rank of Joint Secretary and above have also been authorised to approve related matters, aimed at cutting processing delays.

The ministry said the reforms would free up state legal metrology departments to focus on inspection, enforcement and consumer grievance redressal.

The changes align with recommendations of the International Organization of Legal Metrology, the ministry added.

LNG tanker carrying shipment for India exits Strait of Hormuz for 1st time since war began

NEW DELHI: A liquefied natural gas (LNG) tanker carrying a shipment for India has exited the Strait of Hormuz, the first for the country from the Persian Gulf since the Iran war began months ago as the region's exporters discreetly supply key buyers.

Adnoc Logistics & Services's Al Hamra tanker was spotted in the last day, loaded with a cargo and heading to western India, according to ship-tracking data compiled by Bloomberg.

The vessel stopped sending a signal around April 19 — but at that time it was empty and idling near the eastern entrance of Hormuz. The tanker loaded a cargo at Abu Dhabi National Oil Co's Das Island export plant, which is in the Persian Gulf behind Hormuz, during the period it wasn't sending a



signal, according to Kpler. Satellite images show that LNG tankers have been docking at Das Island, even though no tankers are broadcasting their positions near the plant.

Adnoc has exported two other shipments from the Persian Gulf on tankers that went dark when traversing the waterway — one to Japan and the other to China.

Hormuz has remained virtually shut as the US and Iran

over the last few months, ship data shows. The decline in deliveries has forced India to procure more shipments from the expensive spot market, as well as curb supplies to some industries. LNG tankers linked to Adnoc have stopped transmitting signals around Hormuz and within the Persian Gulf, ship data shows, as a safety measure to protect the vessels and their crew. Adnoc didn't immediately respond to a request for comment outside of regular business hours.

While the move suggests Persian Gulf LNG exporters are finding ways to deliver fuel to customers, it still represents only a fraction of pre-war volumes, when roughly three tankers carrying the super-chilled fuel exited Hormuz on a daily basis.

RIinfra Q4 net profit falls to ₹918.07 crore

NEW DELHI: Reliance Infrastructure (RIinfra) has posted a sharp decline in consolidated net profit at Rs 918.07 crore during Q4 FY26, citing higher expenses.

The company had reported a net profit of Rs 4,387.08 crore in Q4 FY26, RIinfra said in an exchange filing on Friday.

During the latest January-March period, the company's total income fell to Rs 4,154.34 crore from Rs 4,268.05 crore recorded in Q4 FY25.

Expenses, which include multiple components, increased to Rs 5,419.87 crore in the reporting period from Rs 4,827.97 crore in the corresponding quarter of FY25.

The cost of power purchased during the said quarter increased to Rs 3,285.68 crore from Rs 2,739.62 crore in the January-March period of 2024-25.

For the entire FY26, the net profit dipped to Rs 2,900.23 crore from Rs 4,937.52 crore recorded in FY25.

The annual income came down to Rs 20,862.03 crore in FY26 from Rs 23,999.29 crore in the preceding fiscal.

Meanwhile, the company has announced the appointment of Vijesh Babu Thota as the Chief Executive Officer (CEO) effective May 23. Thota was the company's Chief Financial Officer (CFO).

The company has approved the appointment of Ashesh Chaturvedi as the new CFO.

IRFC to raise external commercial borrowing worth \$2 billion to finance large infra projects

NEW DELHI: State-owned Indian Railway Finance Corporation is planning to mobilise \$2 billion through external commercial borrowing (ECB), primarily in Japanese yen, to fund business growth in the current financial year.

The external commercial borrowing is part of the Rs 70,000 crore resource mobilisation plan approved by the board of Indian Railway Finance Corporation (IRFC) for the ongoing financial year.

"We have just signed a loan agreement with the consortium of banks for raising an External Commercial Borrowing loan of JPY equivalent \$1.1 billion. Given the pipeline of projects, we expect disbursements

within the June quarter itself," IRFC Chairman and Managing Director Manoj Kumar Dubey said.

The ECB, being raised for JPY equivalent \$1.1 billion, has been tied up for a 5-year tenor and benchmarked to Overnight TONAR (Tokyo Overnight Average Rate).

The proceeds from this facility will be utilised towards financing projects with forward or backward linkage with the railway sector or any other project as may be approved by the company in compliance with the ECB guidelines.

This is the first ECB being raised by IRFC during FY27 after it had raised Japanese yen equivalent \$700 million across

two ECB transactions in FY26.

The public sector undertaking (PSU) of the Ministry of Railways got Navratna status last year and has set a target of crossing Rs 1 lakh crore loan sanction during the current financial year.

"We are aiming for a loan sanction of Rs 1 lakh crore and disbursement of about Rs 40,000 crore during the ongoing financial year, as the pipeline of high-quality infrastructure projects looks strong," he said.

During FY26, IRFC sanctioned projects worth Rs 72,949 crore and disbursed approximately Rs 35,067 crore, exceeding its annual guidance.

The company witnessed its net worth rising to an all-time

high of Rs 56,748 crore and AUM crossing a record high at Rs 4.85 lakh crore.

The diversification-led expansion resulted in improved spreads and a consistent rise in net interest margin (NIM), while IRFC maintained its zero NPA status.

"Our diversification strategy is now translating into stronger spreads, improved margins and enhanced shareholder value, he said, adding that NIM should further improve to 1.65 per cent in FY27 against 1.5 per cent recorded in FY26.

For FY26, IRFC reported its highest-ever profit of Rs 7,009 crore compared to Rs 6,502 crore in 2024-25, registering a growth of 7.8 per cent.

States can apply for industrial parks under BHAVYA from June 1

NEW DELHI: States can begin submitting applications from June 1 to set up industrial parks under the Rs 33,660 crore Bharat Audyogik Vikas Yojna (BHAVYA), according to an official release issued on Sunday.

The Union Cabinet had approved the scheme on March 18 for developing 100 plug-and-play industrial parks across the country over six years from 2026-27 to 2031-32.

Under the operational guidelines issued by the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT), 50 proposals will be selected in the first phase through two rounds.

The first round will open

on June 1 and close on July 31, 2026, with up to 20 proposals likely to be selected. The second round will run from August 1 to September 30, 2026. States whose proposals are not selected in the first round can resubmit improved applications in the second round.

The scheme aims to create investment-ready, world-class industrial infrastructure to support manufacturing growth and ease of doing business.

According to the guidelines, industrial parks in non-hilly states must have at least 100 acres of contiguous land for development. In hilly states, the northeast, union territories and states with a population

below one crore — including Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Manipur, Meghalaya, Mizoram, Nagaland and Goa — the minimum land requirement is 25 acres.

Out of the 100 parks, up to 20 may have a development area between 500 acres and 1,000 acres. For larger parks proposed in phases, government funding will be capped at 1,000 acres.

Land for the parks can be provided by states, private developers, CPSEs, or jointly, while proposals will be assessed on connectivity, site suitability, industrial ecosystem, policy support and infrastructure quality.

Fuel austerity clouds demand outlook, India's annual product growth forecast cut 40%

The price hikes came just as Prime Minister Narendra Modi urged citizens and government departments to conserve fuel, encourage remote working

NEW DELHI: India's transportation fuel demand growth is expected to slow sharply in the second half of 2026 as government-led fuel conservation measures, elevated crude oil prices and a weakening rupee weigh on mobility and consumption trends, according to energy analysts.

Petrol and diesel prices have been hiked by about Rs 5 per litre each in three instalments since May 15 as oil companies passed on a part of soaring international oil prices to consumers. The price hikes came just as Prime Minister Narendra Modi urged citizens and gov-

ernment departments to conserve fuel, encourage remote working and reduce non-essential travel as elevated energy prices pressure foreign exchange reserves and threaten to widen the current account deficit.

This together with higher prices is likely to have a sobering impact on fuel demand growth.

A report by Elif Binici, Lead Analyst (Modeling) at Kpler, revised down India's 2026 refined products demand growth forecast by about 77,000 barrels per day (kbd), or 39 per cent, to around 78 kbd from an earlier estimate of 128 kbd, citing weaker expected

growth in gasoline and diesel consumption.

Petrol demand faces the steepest downside risk, with growth projected to undershoot the earlier growth estimate by 25 kbd (from 63 kbd to 38 kbd).

Petrol consumption is now estimated at 1010 kbd, down from 1035 kbd amid weaker commuting activity, slower discretionary travel and government fuel-saving campaigns.

Annual diesel demand growth was cut by around 20 kbd, while jet fuel demand growth was revised down nearly 50 per cent to about 6 kbd from 11 kbd previously, reflecting

CLOSER LOOK

- » Petrol & diesel prices have been hiked by about Rs 5 per litre each in three instalments since May 15
- » Petrol demand faces steepest downside risk, with growth projected to undershoot earlier estimate by 25 kbd
- » Petrol consumption is now projected at 1010 kbd against 1035 kbd amid weaker commuting activity, slower discretionary travel, govt fuel-saving campaigns

expectations of reduced air travel and tighter spending patterns.

"The revisions primarily reflect weaker expected growth in gasoline and diesel demand as higher costs, weaker mobil-

ity trends, and recent government-led fuel conservation efforts increasingly feed into domestic transportation activity," according to the report.

The report said India's macroeconomic backdrop had dete-

riorated since the escalation of the US-Iran conflict, with higher crude import costs, refinery expenses and rupee depreciation increasing pressure on inflation and state-run oil marketing companies (OMCs).

The rupee has weakened roughly 6 per cent since the start of the conflict and 10 per cent over the past year. At the same time, FX reserves have reportedly fallen approximately 4.3 per cent since late February as authorities attempt to stabilise the currency, contain imported inflation, and limit volatility in domestic fuel prices.

Retail petrol and diesel

prices, largely frozen since 2022 despite higher global crude prices, were raised by about Rs 5 per litre in three instalments during the last 10 days.

However, the increases remain well below estimated breakeven levels for state-run retailers.

The current national average petrol price of Rs 103 per litre remains far below estimated breakeven levels of nearly Rs 125 per litre, while diesel prices near Rs 94 per litre compare with estimated breakeven levels of Rs 115-120 per litre.

Before the start of the price revision cycle, state-run fuel

retailers were losing roughly Rs 1,000 crore per day as elevated crude procurement costs and currency weakness continued to outpace retail prices.

"The key issue is the inability of state-run retailers to pass through rising import costs quickly enough to restore profitability," the report said.

India's dependence on discounted Russian crude imports, currently estimated at around 1.9-2 million barrels per day, continues to provide a key stabilising force for the domestic fuel market amid ongoing geopolitical uncertainty in the Middle East, it added.

Rubio signals imminent ‘Beneficial & Sustainable’ US-India trade deal

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio asserted that the overall bilateral ties are set to witness an upward trajectory

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India and the US are poised to soon firm up the much-awaited trade agreement that will be both “beneficial” and “sustainable” and will advance the mutual interests of both nations, US Secretary of State Marco Rubio said on Sunday while asserting that the overall bilateral ties are set to witness an upward trajectory.

Rubio, currently on a four-day visit to India, made the remarks after holding wide-ranging talks with External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar that focused on boosting two-way cooperation in areas of trade, critical minerals, energy and defence.

The US Secretary of State’s maiden trip to India is largely seen as an attempt to repair bilateral relations that came under severe strain in the last one year over Washington’s trade and tariff policies. The ties nosedived significantly when the Trump administration hit Indian exports with 50 tariffs, including a 25 levy over Russian energy purchases.

“We are hopeful that our Trade Representative can visit here very soon. We had an Indian delegation in the US. We’ve made tremendous progress, and I think we’re going to



US Secretary of State Marco Rubio speaks during a bilateral meeting with Union External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, unseen, at Hyderabad House, in New Delhi on Sunday

PTI

wind up with a trade agreement between the US and India that is going to be enduring and is going to be beneficial to both sides and sustainable in a way that addresses national interests that we have,” Rubio said at a joint media briefing with Jaishankar.

The external affairs minister underlined the importance of an early understanding on the trade deal. “On the economic front, we spoke about the value of concluding, at an early date, the final text of the interim agreement regarding reciprocal and mutually beneficial trade,” he said. It will be an important step towards a comprehensive

bilateral trade agreement, as envisaged during Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s talks with President Donald Trump during a visit to Washington in February 2025, he said.

In his remarks, Rubio forcefully argued that the Trump administration’s policy on trade is driven by a greater aim to recalibrate Washington’s overall approach on global trade and is not directed against any specific country.

“This is about the US in terms of trade. The President did not say: ‘Let’s figure out a way to create friction with India over trade.’ The President came in and said: ‘We have a trade sit-

Highlights

» ‘Trump administration’s policy on trade is not directed against any specific country’

» ‘There’s a huge imbalance that’s built up and it needs to be addressed’

» The US Secretary of State also cited how the US had problems related to trade with its allies, including the European Union

also good for our trade partners,” he said. “And one of those we hope will be India. In fact, we are on the verge of making that happen. We are hopeful that our trade representative can visit here very soon,” he added.

The US Secretary of State also cited how the US had problems related to trade with its allies, including the European Union. “The difference is that India is a massive economy. This is a big economy where you’re the leading trade partner. We do a lot of trade with India, and so obviously, there’s a big difference between rebalancing trade with a country of this size and magnitude,” he said.

Rubio said the India-US relationship “continues to be strong and in fact, I believe by the end of this administration, it will be stronger than it has ever been. That’s certainly our goal.”

The US Secretary of State also made a mention of India joining the US-backed ‘Pax Silica’ initiative.

The Pax Silica initiative was launched in December to build a secure, resilient, and innovation-driven supply chain for critical minerals & AI. The Pax Silica Summit was held in Washington on December 12 where partner nations signed the Pax Silica declaration. India joined the initiative in February.

Gold & silver may remain rangebound this week

NEW DELHI: Gold and silver prices are likely to remain rangebound in the coming week as traders await more clarity on the evolving US-Iran negotiations, while silver is expected to retain a positive bias amid persistent geopolitical uncertainty and elevated energy rates, analysts said.

Apart from geopolitical developments, investors will also track US housing data, GDP numbers, consumer confidence readings and Personal Consumption Expenditure (PCE) inflation data for further clues on the Federal Reserve’s policy outlook, they added.

“Gold price momentum next week looks sideways, while silver still looks positive as focus will again be on the peace negotiations between the US and Iran to end the war,” said Pranav Mer, Vice President, EBG - Commodity & Currency Research, JM Financial Services Limited.

Gold futures rose marginally to close the previous week at Rs 1.58 lakh per 10 grams, while silver edged lower to settle at Rs 2.71 lakh per kilogram, on the Multi Commodity Exchange (MCX).

In the international markets, Comex gold futures slipped 1 per cent to end the week at \$4,523.2 per ounce, while silver fell nearly 2 per cent to close at \$76.20 per ounce.

PTI

Progress in US-Iran talks, oil prices to drive markets this week: Analysts

NEW DELHI: Developments related to negotiations between the US and Iran to resolve the West Asia conflict, oil prices and foreign investors’ trading activity will largely influence stock markets in a holiday-shortened week, analysts said.

The rupee-dollar trend and global market sentiment would also be tracked by investors, according to the analysts.

“This week is expected to remain highly sensitive to global macroeconomic developments and currency movements. Investors will also monitor crude oil prices, developments in US-Iran negotiations, and the trajectory of the US dollar and bond yields, all of which are expected to influence foreign flows and overall risk appetite,” Ajit Mishra – SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said.



US Secretary of State Marco Rubio on Saturday said that some progress has been made in the negotiations between the US and Iran, signalling that the conflict in West Asia could be nearing a resolution.

The Reserve Bank on Friday announced a record dividend of Rs 2.87 lakh crore to the government for the year ended March 2026, providing a financial boost for the exchequer amid rising import bills and supply chain disruptions due to the West Asia conflict.

Participants will closely assess the impact of the RBI’s record dividend transfer on liquidity expectations, fiscal flexibility, and government spending prospects going forward, Mishra added.

“Markets are expected to remain volatile and heavily headline-driven in the coming week, with investor attention firmly focused on developments surrounding the US-Iran situation, broader diplomatic negotiations and movements in crude oil prices.

Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Limited, said, a more constructive market setup would require crude to ease more meaningfully, FII flows to stabilise, and Q1FY27 earnings expectations to be managed without significant downgrades.

PTI

Uzbekistan seeks greater Indian investment in fintech & digital infra, offers targeted incentives

NEW DELHI: Uzbekistan has created a business-friendly environment for Indian fintech, artificial intelligence (AI), and digital infrastructure companies through targeted incentives, Deputy Minister of Investment, Industry and Trade Shokhrukh Gulamov said.

The country offers preferential tax regimes, access to special economic zones with ready digital infrastructure, and regulatory support for pilot projects, he said. Government policies promoting joint ventures, digital infrastructure investments, and special economic zones are aimed at attracting innovation-driven investments.

Gulamov said Uzbekistan is encouraging public-private

India-Uzbekistan bilateral trade reached \$1.317 bn in 2025, up 33.30% over 2024

partnerships in financial services, e-governance, and smart city projects, opening opportunities for Indian firms to deploy AI and fintech solutions. Indian companies also benefit from streamlined licensing procedures, investment protection frameworks, and collaboration opportunities with local institutions, enabling faster expansion.

He said Uzbekistan’s advantages could help Indian firms

diversify outsourcing operations beyond traditional South Asian hubs, optimise costs, and access skilled talent for high-value services. This, he added, positions Uzbekistan as a strategic base for regional technology expansion while strengthening bilateral economic ties.

Highlighting growing India-Uzbekistan trade relations, Gulamov said bilateral trade reached \$1.317 billion in 2025, marking a 33.30 per cent increase over 2024. Exports stood at \$164.6 million, up 25.4 per cent, while imports rose 34.6 per cent to \$1.153 billion.

Trade volume in early 2026 touched \$300 million, indicating continued momentum despite seasonal fluctuations,

he said.

The two countries have signed 117 bilateral agreements, including the Strategic Partnership Declaration of 2011 and the Investment Protection Agreement signed in September 2024. Institutional mechanisms such as the Intergovernmental Joint Commission and the Uzbekistan-India Business Council are also supporting trade and investment projects.

Indian investments in Uzbekistan are rising steadily. Direct investments reached \$292.9 million in 2025, while 397 Indian-invested enterprises, including 311 joint ventures, were operating in the country by May 2026, Gulamov added.

AGENCIES

Overseas travel spending by Indians falls to \$1.09 bn in March

The outward remittances for travel were at \$1.3 billion in February and \$1.65 billion in January this year

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: Overseas travel spending by Indians, including holiday trips, declined by \$212.43 million to \$1.09 billion in March compared to February, according to the Reserve Bank data.

The outward remittances for travel were at \$1.3 billion in February and \$1.65 billion in January this year.

The RBI data on ‘Outward Remittances under the Liberalised Remittance Scheme (LRS) for Resident Individuals’ shows overseas spending by Indians under different categories, including travel, maintenance of close relatives, studies abroad, investments in equity and debt.

Under the LRS, resident individuals, including minors, are allowed to freely remit up to \$2,50,000 per financial year (April-March) for any permissible current or capital account transaction or a combination of both.

Against the backdrop of the West Asia conflict pushing oil prices higher and pulling down the rupee to record lows, Prime Minister Narendra Modi has urged people to reduce foreign travel and opt for carpooling, among other measures.

With lesser overseas travel, foreign exchange outgo will reduce, and that can help in curbing rupee depreciation.



RBI data showed that total outward remittances stood at \$2.59 billion in March 2026, of which travel accounted for the largest share at \$1.09 billion

The RBI data showed that total outward remittances stood at \$2.59 billion in March 2026, of which travel accounted for the largest share at \$1.09 billion.

The travel category under the LRS has been classified into business travel, pilgrimage, medical treatment, travel for education, and ‘other travel’.

The data showed that Indians spent \$623.05 million under the ‘other travel’ category, which includes holiday trips and international credit card settlements, during March. It accounted for nearly 57 per cent of the total travel outgo of \$1.09 billion.

Mcap of 6 of top-10 cos surges by ₹74,111 cr

NEW DELHI: The combined market valuation of 6 of the top-10 most valued firms surged by Rs 74,111.57 crore last week, with Reliance Industries emerging as the biggest gainer.

Last week, the BSE benchmark climbed 177.36 points, or 0.23 per cent.

From the top-10 pack, Reliance Industries, ICICI Bank, Tata Consultancy Services (TCS), Bajaj Finance, Larsen & Toubro, and Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) were the gainers, while HDFC Bank, Bharti Airtel, State Bank of India and Hindustan Unilever faced erosion from their valuation.

Reliance Industries added Rs 24,696.89 crore, taking its market valuation to Rs 18,33,117.70 crore.

The valuation of TCS jumped Rs 19,338.68 crore to Rs 8,38,401.33 crore, and that of

Market Cap			
Top 10 (BSE)	₹ crore	As on May 22, 2026	Gain/Loss over May 15
RIL		18,33,117.70	▲ 24,696.89
HDFC Bank		11,79,974.90	▼ -2,094.35
Bharti Airtel		11,40,295.49	▼ -20,229.67
ICICI Bank		9,06,901.32	▲ 14,515.93
SBI		8,76,077.92	▼ -12,784.40
TCS		8,38,401.33	▲ 19,338.68
Bajaj Finance		5,70,515.57	▲ 3,797.83
Larsen & Toubro		5,40,228.21	▲ 2,685.87
Hind Unilever		5,17,380.00	▼ -16,212.18
LIC		5,14,443.69	▲ 9,076.37

Source: BSE

KBK Infographics

ICICI Bank surged Rs 14,515.93 crore to Rs 9,06,901.32 crore.

LIC’s valuation climbed Rs 9,076.37 crore to Rs 5,14,443.69

crore.

The market capitalisation (mcap) of Bajaj Finance edged higher by Rs 3,797.83 crore to Rs 5,70,515.57 crore, and that of Larsen & Toubro went up by Rs 2,685.87 crore to Rs 5,40,228.21 crore.

However, the market valuation of Bharti Airtel dropped by Rs 20,229.67 crore to Rs 11,40,295.49 crore.

The mcap of Hindustan Unilever eroded by Rs 16,212.18 crore to Rs 5,17,380 crore, and that of State Bank of India declined by Rs 12,784.40 crore to Rs 8,76,077.92 crore.

HDFC Bank’s mcap dipped by Rs 2,094.35 crore to Rs 11,79,974.90 crore.

Reliance Industries retained the title of the most valued firm, followed by HDFC Bank, Bharti Airtel, ICICI Bank, State Bank of India, TCS, Bajaj Finance, Larsen & Toubro, Hindustan Unilever and LIC.

PTI

‘Govt in advanced stage of talks on cotton import duty removal’



Agriculture, finance & textiles ministries, are deliberating on duty, with textile industry seeking its removal

that the consultation will be finalised in the near future,” the official said.

A delegation comprising apparel industry representatives and exporters met Vice President C P Radhakrishnan and several Union ministers recently and sought the removal of the duty.

The delegation argued that the textile industry’s cotton requirement for the current year is projected at around 337 lakh bales, whereas cotton arrivals for the 2025-26 season are estimated at 292.15 lakh bales, resulting in a supply-demand gap of nearly 45 lakh bales.

PTI

Cement makers expect 7-8% growth in current fiscal despite West Asia headwinds

Cement makers said premiumisation and a better trade mix are helping improve realisations even in a relatively stable pricing environment

NEW DELHI: Leading cement manufacturers expect the industry to grow 7-8 per cent in FY27, driven by government infrastructure spending, housing demand and urbanisation, despite near-term pressure from rising fuel and freight costs linked to the West Asia crisis.

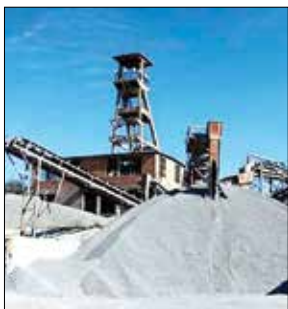
Executives of major companies, including UltraTech Cement, Ambuja Cements, Shree Cement, Dalmia Bharat and Nuvoco Vistas, expressed optimism about medium-term demand in their latest earnings calls, while highlighting premiumisation and improved trade mix as key drivers of earnings

growth.

UltraTech Chief Financial Officer Atul Daga said the industry is facing headwinds from higher fuel prices, freight costs and import-dependent supply chains amid geopolitical tensions in West Asia. Power, fuel and selling expenses account for nearly 50-55 per cent of cement companies’ operating costs.

“It’s a real headwind on fuel costs, packing bags and freight,” Daga said, adding that elevated crude oil prices may also push up domestic petrol and diesel prices.

However, he maintained



that India’s long-term growth outlook remains strong, backed by government capital expenditure, infrastructure execution and robust housing demand. UltraTech is targeting double-

CLOSER LOOK

» Dalmia Bharat MD & CEO Puneet Dalmia said the firm would continue to pursue premiumisation in FY27

» Dalmia Bharat plans capex of Rs 3,200-3,400 cr in FY27, while UltraTech said it will continue investing Rs 8,000-10,000 cr annually over next four to five years

» Ambuja Cements has earmarked Rs 6,000-6,500 crore for FY27, while Nuvoco Vistas has planned Rs 900 crore capex for FY27 and Rs 960 crore for FY28

Executive Officer Vinod Bahety projected the company’s consolidated volumes to rise around 8 per cent in FY27 to nearly 80 million tonnes, aided by a stronger focus on trade sales

and premium cement. At the industry level, however, he expects demand growth to remain moderate at 5-5.5 per cent due to inflation concerns and the possibility of a weak monsoon.

Cement makers said premiumisation and a better trade mix are helping improve realisations even in a relatively stable pricing environment. UltraTech said grey cement prices strengthened around 2.5 per cent across most regions during the quarter.

Dalmia Bharat Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer Puneet Dalmia said the

company would continue to aggressively pursue premiumisation in FY27, adding that realisations improved 1.7 per cent sequentially.

Shree Cement Managing Director Neeraj Akhoury said geopolitical tensions and forecasts of a moderate monsoon could temporarily impact momentum, though domestic demand fundamentals remain resilient.

Nuvoco Vistas Managing Director Jayakumar Krishnaswamy cautioned that margins may remain under pressure for one to two quarters because of rising fuel, raw material and

packaging costs, along with currency volatility. Still, he projected industry growth of 7-9 per cent in the coming year, supported by infrastructure spending.

Companies are also stepping up investments. Dalmia Bharat plans capital expenditure of Rs 3,200-3,400 crore in FY27, while UltraTech said it will continue investing Rs 8,000-10,000 crore annually over the next four to five years. Ambuja Cements has earmarked Rs 6,000-6,500 crore for FY27, while Nuvoco Vistas has planned Rs 900 crore capex for FY27 and Rs 960 crore for FY28.

AGENCIES

RR seal fourth playoff spot

Jofra Archer powers Rajasthan Royals into IPL playoffs with 30-run win over Mumbai Indians

MUMBAI: Rajasthan Royals rode on Jofra Archer's all-round brilliance to book the fourth and final play-off berth with a 30-run victory over Mumbai Indians in the Indian Premier League here on Sunday.

Archer returned with splendid figures of 4-0-17-3 after his 15-ball 32 helped Royals reach a fighting 205 for 8 after 20 overs.

It was 73 runs in the last five overs bowled by Mumbai Indians which proved to be decisive as Mumbai Indians could manage only 175 for 9 in 20 overs.

The victory lifted Rajasthan Royals to the fourth position in the IPL points table with 16 points, effectively knocking out Punjab Kings, Kolkata Knight Riders, and even Delhi Capitals — latter two had slim outside chances. Mumbai Indians' reply was spruced with a timely half-century from Suryakumar Yadav — 60 off 42 balls with four sixes and three fours — as well as skipper Hardik Pandya's 15-ball 34 and Will Jacks' 33 off 18 balls. But none of these efforts were enough to revive the five-time winners, who had slipped to 38 for four with Archer's two-wicket burst at the start.

The collapse began when Archer produced a jaffa — a perfect outswinger which darted sharply away from Rohit Sharma (0) who went on a fishing expedition away from his body. The resultant edge settled into wicketkeeper Dhruv Jurel's gloves.

Archer then got one to nip off the surface to hit the wickets and see the back of Naman Dhir (6) in the third over, but the body blow came for MI in the form of Ryan Rickelton's (12) dismissal off Burger, who found Vaibhav Sooryavanshi at square leg. A disappointing season had no different end for Tilak Varma with the



Rajasthan Royals' Dhruv Jurel, left, celebrates with teammate Jofra Archer after taking a catch to dismiss Mumbai Indians' Rohit Sharma during an Indian Premier League match against Mumbai Indians in Mumbai on Sunday

73 It was 73 runs in the last five overs bowled by MI which proved to be decisive as Mumbai Indians could manage only 175 for 9 in 20 overs

bat when the India batter was undone by a Brijesh Sharma delivery which kept low while he attempted to flick it. In a season marred by poor powerplay returns, Mumbai Indians had no respite in their final outing where they finished at 49 for four after six overs. Suryakumar also rode

his luck, getting two reprieves en route to his second half-century of the season. Brijesh missed a run-out chance on either ends when both Ryan Rickelton and Suryakumar were caught in a mix-up with an awful throw, and then dropped a catch at mid-wicket when the MI batter on 27 off

Yash Raj Punja in the eighth over. Suryakumar and Jacks put on 63 for the fifth wicket in an impressive turnaround for the hosts, but it was Pandya's dismissal off Archer in the 16th over — when MI were still in the chase — that shut them out of the game. With 59 needed off 30 balls and Archer steaming in

for his final over, MI could have opted against going after the English pacer but Pandya took the punt that fell flat.

A mis-hit ended Pandya's quickfire innings during which he made animated gestures, while also sharp caught-and-bowled from Nandre Burger (2/43) of Suryakumar in the 18th over sealed the deal.

Earlier, Archer (32 off 15 balls) and Ravindra Jadeja's (19 no off 11 balls) vital contributions late in the innings lifted Rajasthan Royals to an under-par 205 for eight on a benign wicket.

DC FINISH SIXTH

Rahul blitz, Kuldeep magic sink Kolkata in final league game

KOLKATA: Kuldeep Yadav marked his return in stunning three-wicket haul to complement KL Rahul's blazing half-century at the top as Delhi Capitals outclassed an out of sorts Kolkata Knight Riders by 40 runs, in an inconsequential final league match of the IPL here on Sunday.

Rahul was at his explosive best, smashing five fours and four sixes in a 30-ball 60, his sixth fifty of the season, as Delhi Capitals posted a formidable 203/5 after Ajinkya Rahane opted to bowl.

In reply, comeback left-arm wrist spinner Kuldeep tormented his former franchise with a decisive spell, first removing Cameron Green (2) cheaply before striking twice in two balls to dismiss Rahane (63) and Rinku Singh (0) off successive deliveries.

He nearly claimed a hat-trick as well when KKR wicketkeeper Tejasvi Dahiya edged the very next delivery, only for Abhishek Porel to spill the chance behind the stumps.

Kuldeep, who had gone wicketless in his previous three matches before being left out, returned with brilliant figures of 3/29.

KKR's chase unravelled



Delhi Capitals' Mitchell Starc, left, takes a catch of Kolkata Knight Riders' Kartik Tyagi during the match, in Kolkata on Sunday

after Rahane's dismissal as they were bundled out for 163 in 18.4 overs to slump to their seventh defeat of the season.

Mitchell Starc, bowling against the franchise with whom he won the IPL title last season, also chipped in with 2/26 (3 overs).

Lungi Ngidi (3/27; 3.4 overs) took the last wicket of Varun Chakravarthy as Delhi Capitals finished with seven wins, seven losses to climb above KKR to finish sixth in the standings. KKR ended seventh with six wins from 14 matches for yet another poor season under Rahane.

Under Rahane's leadership, KKR had endured a disappointing 2025 campaign as well, finishing eighth, the first time since 2009. Possibly

bly playing his final match for the franchise, the 37-year-old Rahane produced one of his finest knocks of the season to keep KKR in the chase.

Express pacer Ngidi made early inroads, dismissing the dangerous Finn Allen (20) in the powerplay before removing Manish Pandey (25) when he was attempting to rebuild alongside Rahane. AGENCIES

NORTH EASTERN RAILWAY
Dy.Chief Electrical Engineer/Colony, N.E. Railway, Gorakhpur for & behalf of President of India Invites "OPEN" E-Tender through online (e-tendering) for the following work : **Tender Notice No. & Description of Work:** 04-2026-Colony, **Name of work:-** Gorakhpur- Replacement of 11 KV H.T. Panels for Commercial supply on the basis of outdated technology at 33/11 KV substations. Approx. Value: ₹ 3,65,80,328.00. E.M.D. Money: ₹ 7,31,600.00, Cost of Tender Form - Zero Completion time/period from the date of issue of acceptance letter - 09 Months. E-tender online will be submitted up to 15:00 Hrs on date 15.06.2026 Manual offer are not allowed against these tenders and any such manual offer received shall be ignored. For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railway IREPS official website www.ireps.gov.in
Dy. Chief Electrical Engineer/ CPRO/EL-51 Colony,Gorakhpur
Never travel on roof and foot boards.

Gukesh, Praggnanandhaa lead India's charge at Norway Chess

OSLO: World champion D Gukesh will have a shot at rediscovering his touch ahead of his world championship title defence when he launches his campaign at the prestigious Norway Chess on Monday, facing another stern test of temperament and skill against an elite field.

The elite field is headlined by former world No. 1 Magnus Carlsen and, besides Gukesh, also features Indian star R Praggnanandhaa, with a formidable Indian contingent aiming to end the country's long-standing wait for a maiden title in the picturesque surroundings of Oslo and its scenic fjords.

The carefully chosen venue, the iconic Deichman Bjorvika public library over-

looking the Oslofjord waterfront and located just a couple of kilometres from the Nobel Peace Center, will host six of the world's best players in both the Open and Women's sections. India, now firmly established as a global chess powerhouse, will have four representatives in the event -- Gukesh and Praggnanandhaa in the Open category, alongside Koneru Humpy and World Cup winner Divya Deshmukh in the women's field.

The task, however, will be anything but easy for the Indian quartet, with world No. 1 and home favourite Carlsen leading a formidable field that includes French star Alireza Firouzja.

Need to consider a reset: Tom Moody hints at leadership change at LSG

LUCKNOW: Lucknow Super Giants are set to consider a leadership overhaul after enduring two dismal IPL campaigns, with Director of Cricket Tom Moody admitting skipper Rishabh Pant has struggled to handle the pressures of captaincy.

After finishing seventh in 2025, LSG are set to end the 2026 season in either ninth or 10th place, depending on Mumbai Indians' final result. Under Pant's captaincy, the franchise managed only 10 wins in 28 matches across two seasons. "From a captaincy point of view, you know, he's found it challenging, obviously, and the results reflect that," Moody said told report-

Under Pant's captaincy, the franchise managed only 10 wins in 28 matches across two seasons

ers after the seven-wicket loss to Punjab Kings on Saturday. "And you do have to wonder whether that is a pressure that is reflected with his performance with the bat. I know that this season has been a difficult season for us, but we will reflect on it, we'll take time, we'll reflect on it. We'll consider all things."

Barcelona rout storied rival OL Lyonnes in Women's Champions League final

Pajor struck with an arrowing low shot in 55th minute

OSLO: Barcelona rose again to the peak of European soccer by routing its most storied rival OL Lyonnes 4-0 in an overwhelming second-half display in the Women's Champions League final on Saturday.

Barcelona forward Ewa Pajor lost in her first five visits to the European title match but the former Wolfsburg star made her sixth try count with two goals.

Pajor struck with an arrowing low shot in the 55th minute and a close-range finish in the 69th when the Barcelona attack was queuing up to score past the stretched Lyon defense.

Salma Paralluelo turned the screw on Lyon by firing in a rising left-shot in the 90th and adding another slick finish in stoppage time.

The decisive first goal was created by a surging 40-yard run and assist by Patri Guizarro, often overlooked in a stellar midfield alongside Ballon d'Or winners Aitana Bonmati and Alexia Putellas.

Barcelona has swept all four domestic and international trophies this season and is a four-time European champion in just six sea-



Barcelona's Claudia Pina celebrates with the trophy after winning the Women's Champions League final football match between FC Barcelona and OL Lyonnes, in Oslo

sons — a dynasty in women's soccer and replacing Lyon which dominated the previous decade.

One year ago, Barcelona was denied another trophy sweep by a surprising 1-0 loss to Arsenal in the final.

In the dugout on Saturday it was a victory for a former assistant over his one-time boss.

Barcelona coach Pere Romeu was an assistant to Jonatan Giraldez, now with Lyon, when the Catalan giant won back-to-back

Champions Leagues in 2023 and '24.

Lyon's bright start It was a cruel end for Lyon which also was seeking a quadruple of trophies this season and impressed early. Lyon stifled Barcelona's intent to control play with neat passing, and was typically strong with set-pieces.

Barcelona goalkeeper Cata Coll saved well in the first half from Wendie Renard's header and a free kick by left back Selma Bacha that curled toward the top corner.

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BEFORE MICRO & SMALL ENTERPRISES FACILITATION COUNCIL Plot No.39, INDL AREA, PHASE-II, CHANDIGARH.
Case No. 469/2025
M/S DARTWELL XPRESS PRIVATE LIMITED (DIRECTOR- JUDGE BHOL SINGH) HAVING REGISTERED OFFICE AT QUIT OFFICE NO. 13, 2ND FLOOR, SECTOR 35-A, CHANDIGARH 160036.

.....Claimant
VERSUS
M/S EXCEL CARGO MOVERS (PROP. SUMAN LATWA/O SUNIL KUMAR) R/O
(a) GROUND FLOOR, PLOT IN KHASRA NO.959, VILLAGE MAHIPALPUR, NEAR BAI PASS ROAD, MAHIPALPUR, NEW DELHI, 110037.
(b) PANA PACHOSIA, MANDHOTI (53), JHAJJAR, MANDHOTI HARYANA, 124506.

....Respondent
Whereas the claimant has initiated arbitration proceedings in terms of Section-18 of MSMED Act, 2006 before this Council against you.

Therefore, you are hereby directed to file your statement of defence in this Court in person or by a pleader on or before **01.07.2026 at 02:30 P.M.**, failing which the matter shall be proceeded with and decided ex-parte in accordance with law. This notice is issued under the directions of the competent authority.
Authority Address: as above
For Chairman
MSEFC, U.T., Chandigarh

SOHA GROUP
Building Value For Your World

RERA : HRERA-PKL-FBD-705-2025

Applications are invited online from General Public for booking of Residential Flats in the "OLIVE HOMES" an Affordable Group Housing Project, to be developed at Sector 98, Faridabad, by M/s. SOHA REALTY PVT. LTD., as per the terms and conditions of the policy prescribed by Town & Country Planning Department, Government of Haryana vide notification No. PF-27/48921 dated 19.08.2013, amended upto date (details available at the website of the department i.e. tcp.haryana.gov.in)

Project Details									
1. Project :	"OLIVE HOMES"								
2. Project Approvals :	M/s. SOHA REALTY PVT. LTD. Licence No./Year: 125 of 2024 dated 23.10.2024 Building Plan Approved on dated: 22.04.2025 vide Memo No. ZP-2075/PA(DK)/2025/14430								
:	RERA No.- HRERA-PKL-FBD-705-2025 Dated : 27.05.2025								
3. Location :	Sector-98, Faridabad, Haryana								
4. Provisions :	Project Area: 8.20625 Acres, comprising of a Total 1184 No. of Flats out of which 5% flats are reserved for management quota and balance 95% flats are available for sale to the General Public. Common Facilities: One Community Hall of 2665 Sq.ft. (Approx.) and One Anganwadi-Cum-Creche of 2665 Sq.ft. (approx.) As per rates prescribed under the policy notified vide Memo No. PF-27/48921 dated 19.08.2013, amended upto date Vide Memo No. PF-27-Vol-III/ 2026/11396 Dated: 08.04.2026 issued by the Principal Secretary to the Government of Haryana, Town and Country Planning Department, Chandigarh (details available at the website of the department i.e. tcp.haryana.gov.in) Sale Price (On Carpet Area): Rs 5,450/- PSF (additional cost of Balcony @Rs.1300/- PSF subject to maximum of 100 Sq.ft.). PARKING: - Two-wheeler parking with each apartment.								
5. Facilities :	Gated Entry, Security post, Open Seating & Kids Play Area, Walking Track, Open GYM & Commercial.								
Payment Plan									
1. With Application: 5% BSP of Flat, on Booking 2. On Allotment: 25% of the Total Allotment Price along with applicable GST, Less Booking Amount. 3. Balance :75%with applicable GST is as per DTCP Policy for Affordable Group Housing Project i.e., Construction Linked Payment Plan. Any default in payment will attract penal interest as provided in Rule 15 of the Haryana Real Estate Regulatory Authority									
APPLICATION TIMELINES :	1. Application form will be filled online by registering on the website https://edraw.tcp.haryana.gov.in/tcp-dms/home w.e.f 11.05.2026 2. Last Date of submission of the Application: 28.05.2026								
Inventory Details									
Unit Category	Unit Type	Carpet Area in Sqft	Balcony Area in Sqft	Total of No. of Flats	BSP of Flat	Balcony Cost	Total BSP of flat with Balcony cost	Booking Amount (5% of BSP of flat)	On Allotment (25% of BSP of the Flat & Balcony Less Booking Amount)
1BHK	TYPE-A	403.46	167.49	24	₹ 21,98,857	₹ 1,30,000	₹ 23,28,857	₹ 1,09,943	₹ 4,72,271
1BHK	TYPE-A	398.27	117.55	16	₹ 21,70,572	₹ 1,30,000	₹ 23,00,572	₹ 1,08,529	₹ 4,66,614
1BHK	TYPE-A	401.09	45.32	56	₹ 21,85,941	₹ 58,916	₹ 22,44,857	₹ 1,09,297	₹ 4,51,917
1BHK	TYPE-B	398.27	117.55	16	₹ 21,70,572	₹ 1,30,000	₹ 23,00,572	₹ 1,08,529	₹ 4,66,614
1BHK	TYPE-B	407.63	66.74	56	₹ 22,21,584	₹ 86,762	₹ 23,08,346	₹ 1,11,079	₹ 4,66,007
2BHK	TYPE-A	573.29	202.58	312	₹ 31,24,431	₹ 1,30,000	₹ 32,54,431	₹ 1,56,222	₹ 6,57,386
2BHK	TYPE-A	556.31	160.17	184	₹ 30,31,890	₹ 1,30,000	₹ 31,61,890	₹ 1,51,594	₹ 6,38,878
2BHK	TYPE-B	573.63	136.28	184	₹ 31,26,284	₹ 1,30,000	₹ 32,56,284	₹ 1,56,314	₹ 6,57,757
2BHK	2BHK-14th Floor	532.54	214.74	24	₹ 29,02,343	₹ 1,30,000	₹ 30,32,343	₹ 1,45,117	₹ 6,12,969
3BHK		644.99	215.28	312	₹ 35,15,196	₹ 1,30,000	₹ 36,45,196	₹ 1,75,760	₹ 7,35,539
Total Units: 1184									
✓ 5% Management Quota Applicable ✓ GST @ 1% shall be charged extra. ✓ Rate mentioned above does not include other charges such as Stamp Duty, Registration Fees of Agreement to Sell as well as Conveyance Deed.									
BROAD SPECIFICATIONS Flooring: Rooms- Vitrified Tiles/ Ceramic Tiles, Kitchen- Vitrified Tiles/ Ceramic Tiles, Toilet- Anti Skid Tiles, Balcony- Anti Skid I.P.S./ and any other material as decided by the Developer, Door/Window Frame- M.S. Hollow Section any other frame as decided by the developer, Door Shutters-Flush Doors Painted with Enamel Paint or any other shutter as decided by the Developer, Wall Tiles-Bathroom Ceramic Tiles, Kitchen- Vitrified Tiles/ Ceramic Tiles to 2 Feet height above counter, Kitchen Platform - Marble Stone/ Granite, Wall Finish-Colour Wash/Dry Distemper, Plumbing Fitting-PPR Pipes/CPVC Pipes/UPVC Pipes or equivalent, Sanitary Fitting-Chinaware and CP Fittings, Electric Switches / Wiring-ISI Marked or equivalent, Structure-RCC frames Structure designed for SEISMIC forces as per latest IS Code.									
ELIGIBILITY: Any person can apply, however, the PMAY beneficiaries, which include their spouse or dependent children, identified by the Urban Local Bodies Department, Haryana under "Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojna-Housing for All" programme shall be granted preference in allotment. First priority shall be given to the identified beneficiaries of the said town followed by other PMAY beneficiaries of the State of Haryana. Thereafter, for the remaining flats, persons which include their spouse or dependent children who do not own any flat/plot in any HUDA developed colony/sector or any licensed colony in any of the Urban areas in Haryana, UT of Chandigarh and NCT Delhi shall be given next preference in allotment of flats. An applicant in a specific colony shall make only one application. Any successful applicant under this policy shall not be eligible for allotment of any other flat under this policy in any other colony. In case he/she is successful in more than one colony, he/she will have choice to retain only one flat. All such applicants shall submit an affidavit to this effect". PAN Card & Aadhar Card is compulsory.									
ALLOTMENT CRITERIA: - i) The allotment of flats shall be done through draw of lots in the presence of committee consisting of Deputy Commissioner or his representative (at least of the Cadre of Haryana Civil Services), Senior Town Planner, (circle office), DTP of the concerned district and the representative of coloniser concerned. ii) After fixation of the date of draw of lots, an advertisement shall be issued by the Developer, informing the applicants about the details regarding date/time and venue of the draw of lots in the same newspapers in which the original advertisement was issued. iii) For detailed criteria and time frame to be adopted for scrutiny and allotment, the applicants may also refer to the details mentioned in the Affordable Housing Policy-2013 dated 19.08.2013 notified Vide Memo. PF-27-Vol-III/ 2026/11396 Dated: 08.04.2026, amended upto date (available at the Department website i.e. tcp.haryana.gov.in)									
Note: The surrendered/withdrawn applicants of successful applicants of earlier draws of any project are to get the status updated in the STP office, Faridabad, before filing the application in the current project within 02 weeks of publication of this Notice.									
SOHA REALTY PVT. LTD. Corp. Address: - B-27, Ground Floor, Vipul Plaza, Sector-81, Faridabad, Haryana-121002					OLIVE HOMES AFFORDABLE HOUSING Ekhar Zindagi, Har Day				
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‘BOLLYWOOD NO LONGER SETS TRENDS’

Karan Johar believes that audiences no longer want to dress like Kareena Kapoor Khan, Alia Bhatt or Deepika Padukone

Long ago, whenever a film became a blockbuster or a daily soap turned into a cultural phenomenon, audiences would rush to imitate their favourite stars - from hairstyles to bridal outfits. In fact, after Anushka Sharma married Virat Kohli in 2017, pastel bridal lehengas became a massive trend among brides across India because she had worn one at her wedding. However, filmmaker Karan Johar now believes that audiences no longer want to dress like Bollywood celebrities such as Kareena Kapoor Khan, Alia Bhatt or Deepika Padukone. According to him, the biggest reason behind this shift is people's growing desire for individuality. Speaking on 'The Barber-Shop with Shantani', Karan, who is also the founder

of the jewellery brand 'Tyaani', said, "Earlier, there used to be a gold standard that Bollywood has worn it. Now, there is a certain attitude about that, too. People are like, 'Why should I wear this? Kareena has already worn it' or 'Alia Bhatt and Deepika Padukone have already worn it'. They don't want to wear the same thing because they don't want to come across as someone copying a Bollywood star. Nobody wants to look like a wannabe version of a celebrity anymore. Everybody is seeking individuality." He further explained how luxury fashion consumers now want personalised experiences instead of celebrity-inspired styling. "When people go to Manish Malhotra, they often say, 'I don't want to wear what X, Y or Z has worn'. Everybody wants individual treatment. They want customer service that feels tailored specifically to them. They want to feel special. Their mindset is: 'We are paying you, so what are you giving us that you are not giving someone else?' There's now a strong demand



for exclusivity and individual catering," he shared. Interestingly, Manish Malhotra himself had once spoken about a very different era, a time when copying celebrity fashion was considered aspirational rather than repetitive. AGENCIES

According to him, the biggest reason behind this shift is people's growing desire for individuality

‘Elephants in the Fog’ creates history at Cannes

The Nepali film took home the Un Certain Regard Jury Prize at the film festival

CANNES: Nepali film 'Elephants in the Fog' created history by becoming the first film from the country to win at Cannes, taking home the Un Certain Regard Jury Prize at the 79th edition of the world's most prestigious film festival. Written and directed by Abinash Bikram Shah in his feature debut, the film was also the first Nepali film to be selected in the segment, which runs parallel to the main competition for the Palme d'Or and highlights emerging filmmakers and distinctive storytelling voices.

Set in Thori, a forested village in Nepal's southern Terai plains, 'Elephants in the Fog' follows the lives of transgender women living on the margins of their community. The story is mainly about Pirati, the matriarch of a Kinnar community, who dreams of escaping to live with the man she loves. But when one of her daughters goes missing, she must investigate and choose between her desire for freedom and her responsibilities to her community, according to the official logline.

In his acceptance speech, Shah said cinema has the power to look into the shadows. He was accompanied by the film's cast on stage. "For so long, the lives of Pirati and her daughters, the communities and all the persons who are in the East, have been kept invisible. By bringing our story here and by recognising it with this award, we have pulled those margins into the light. We have made the invisible visible," he said, dedicating the honour to his team.

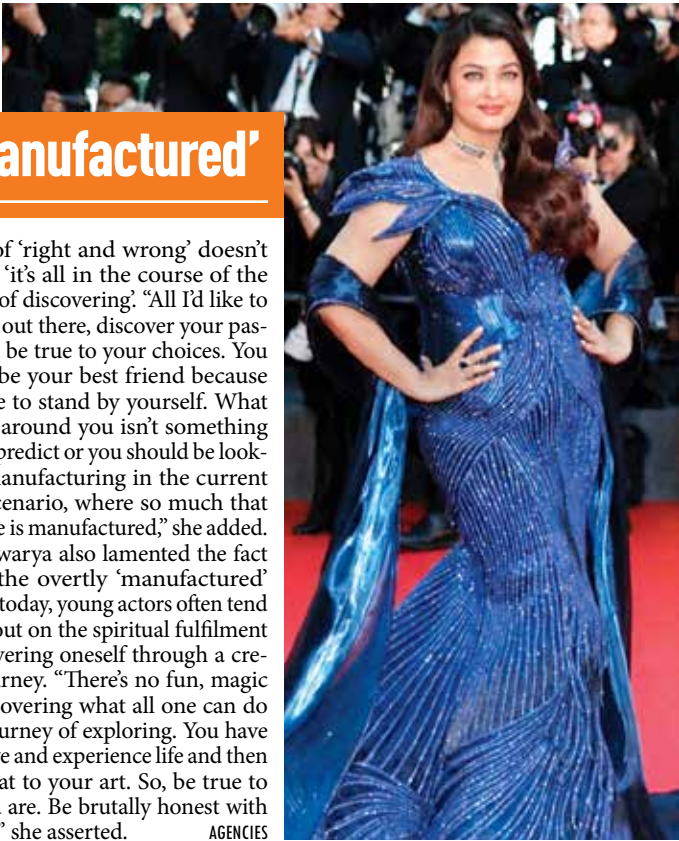
'Elephants in the Fog' features Pushpa Thing, Deepika Yadav, Jas-



In his acceptance speech, Abinash Bikram Shah said cinema has the power to look into the shadows

mine Bishwakarma, Shanti Giri, Gauri Malla, Maotse Gurung, Sanjay Gupta Dura, Mahima Nawab and Akanksha Karki. The film is a co-production between Nepali companies 'Underground Talkies Nepal' and 'Jayanthi Creations', with partners from France, Germany, Brazil and Norway.

Shah is no stranger to Cannes. His earlier short film 'Lori' received a 'Special Mention' at the 75th edition of the festival, becoming the first Nepali short to earn that recognition. His previous writing credits include 'Kalo Pothi', 'Highway' and 'Tatini', all screened at various international festivals. PTI



‘In current world scenario, so much is manufactured’

After days of making fans back home and around the world wait, Aishwarya Rai Bachchan finally walked the red carpet at the Cannes Film Festival 2026. She once again graced the red carpet on Saturday for the closing ceremony of the prestigious film festival.

At the festival, when Aishwarya was asked to offer advice to young, aspiring female actors of today, she smiled and responded, "As an artiste, honestly, I continue to feel each day is a new day. And you're yourself on this road of discovery on this journey of creativity. So, to be put in a position where a mic is held to you and you're asked for advice, it's a bit exalting to be put on a pulpit, which in all humility, you're still working and striving to earn that kind of adulation."

"I'm grateful for the love and support. Thank you so much for the appreciation, but I truly feel your jour-

Aishwarya Rai Bachchan graced the red carpet on Saturday for the closing ceremony of the Cannes Film Festival 2026

ney in the artistic world or any world you choose is individual. And your experiences are what will enrich you and help you discover what choices you can make. Because different strokes for different folks. So, you don't know what's going to work for you, what's right or wrong," she added in her interview with 'Brut India'.

Aishwarya Rai clarified that the

binary of 'right and wrong' doesn't exist, as 'it's all in the course of the journey of discovering.' "All I'd like to say is go out there, discover your passion and be true to your choices. You have to be your best friend because you have to stand by yourself. What goes on around you isn't something you can predict or you should be looking at manufacturing in the current world scenario, where so much that gets done is manufactured," she added.

Aishwarya also lamented the fact that in the overtly 'manufactured' world of today, young actors often tend to miss out on the spiritual fulfilment of discovering oneself through a creative journey. "There's no fun, magic and discovering what all one can do in the journey of exploring. You have to be alive and experience life and then bring that to your art. So, be true to who you are. Be brutally honest with yourself," she asserted. AGENCIES

‘Fjord’ wins Palme d'Or at Cannes Film Festival

The win for the film extends one of the movie's most extraordinary streaks

Cristian Mungiu's Norway-set drama about political polarisation, 'Fjord', won the Palme d'Or, handing the Cannes Film Festival's top honour for the second time to Mungiu, the Romanian director of '4 Months, 3 Weeks and 2 Days'. At the 79th Cannes Film Festival that saw few films cause a stir, 'Fjord' found wide admiration for its engrossing tale of what Mungiu called 'left-wing fundamentalism'. It stars Sebastian Stan and Renate Reinsve as Romanian Evangelicals who move to Norway, but soon their children are taken from them by child services for spanking them.

"Today, society is split. It's divided. It's radicalised," said Mungiu. "This film is a pledge against any type of fundamentalism. It's a pledge for these things we quote very often, like trauma and inclusion and empathy. These are lovely words, but we need to apply them more often."

Mungiu becomes just the 10th filmmaker to win the Palme d'Or twice. His '4 Months, 3 Weeks and 2 Days', a Romanian abortion drama, won the award in 2007.

The win for 'Fjord' extends one of the movie's most extraordinary streaks. 'Neon', the speciality label, has now taken seven Palme d'Or winners in a row. 'Fjord' adds to its unparalleled run, including last year's champion, Jafar Panahi's 'It Was Just an Accident' and the 2024 winner, 'Anora'. The latter went on to win 'Best Picture' at the Oscars.

The Grand Prix or second prize went to 'Minotaur', Andrey Zvyagintsev's domes-



tic thriller set against Russia's war with Ukraine. Loosely based on Claude Chabrol's 1969 film 'The Unfaithful Wife', 'Minotaur' is about a Russian businessman suspicious of his wife's indiscretions. At the same time, he's tasked with conscripting 150 of his workers for Vladimir Putin's war machine.

By wide consensus, it wasn't a banner festival. Hollywood largely sat out this year's edition. Many of the selections struggled to bowl over critics. The global buzz that Cannes typically generates was fitful at best. But the awards handed out on Saturday, as the 79th Cannes drew to a close, will significantly raise the international profiles of the winners. The nine-member jury that decided the awards was headed by Korean filmmaker Park Chan-wook. Demi Moore, Chloe Zhao and Stellan Skarsgard were also jurors. Chan-wook, a Cannes regular including last year with his satirical thriller 'No Other Choice', joked that he preferred not to give away the Palme.

Awards were split and shared. Two films won for 'Best Director': the Polish filmmaker Pawel Paw-

likowski, for his postwar drama 'Fatherland' and the Spanish creative duo Javier Ambrossi and Javier Calvo for 'The Black Ball', a generation-spanning queer epic 'The Black Ball'.

Virginie Efira and Tao Okamoto, the two stars of Ryusuke Hamaguchi's 'All of a Sudden' shared the 'Best Actress' award. In the elegantly empathetic drama, the two play women brought together in friendship out of their mutual sense of care for others.

The jury also split the 'Best Actor' prize. They chose Emmanuel Macchia and Valentin Campagne, the two stars of 'Coward', Lukas Dhont's drama about young Belgian men sent to the front lines of World War II.

The prize for 'Best Screenplay' was awarded to Emmanuel Marre for 'A Man of His Time', a French drama about a Nazi collaborator in Vichy France. Marre based it on the experiences of his own great-grandfather.

The jury prize or third place went to German filmmaker Valeska Grisebach's 'The Dreamed Adventure', a crime drama set in a Bulgarian border town. AGENCIES

THE CINEMA OF APNAPAN

In Anuj Sharma's Chhattisgarhi films, dialect is not merely speech. It is memory and belonging

AUTHOR



DARSHIM SAXENA

About a week after Anuj Sharma turned 50, I found myself thinking not of his filmography first, but of his two names.

He carries one piece of paper on which both appear. Ramanuj, the name his mother spoke into him in Bhatapara. Anuj, the name a marketing boss at 'Godrej', preferred. Between them lie three decades of a single life. The Padma Shri certificate of 2014 is the only document on which the state agreed that both names belonged to the same man.

That detail stayed with me because Anuj's cinema too stands between names. Between dialect and language. Between local memory and public recognition. Between what a file calls regional and what an audience calls its own. In the conversation we



A still from Anuj Sharma's Chhattisgarhi cinema, rooted in the language, gestures and everyday worlds of its people

recorded for 'The Second Seat', Anuj described Chhattisgarh not by district but by colour. Black in the north, where the coal sits. White in the centre, where the limestone is. Red in the south, in Bastar, where iron ore runs under Bailadila's hills. The cinema halls are mostly in the white belt.

The black and red belts have very few. The old Bastar region, larger than Kerala before it was administratively broken up, once had three. What the map calls one state,

the ear knows as many countries as possible. I asked him what happens when Chhattisgarhi arrives on screen. He used a word no constitutional schedule can fully hold, 'apnapan'. The feeling that something is yours.

In his films, dialect is not merely speech. It is an address. It is the rhythm of teasing, blessing, flirting, scolding and grieving. A love story stops being only a love story when it speaks in the cadence of your courtyard, your wedding song,

your neighbour's joke and your mother's half-said sentence. The plot may be familiar. The emotion may be old. But the address changes everything.

That address matters because India often discusses regional cinema through market size, subtitles, release counts and industry labels. But for the first audience of such a film, the achievement is more intimate. It is not only that they understand the words. It is the words that they understand them. The joke

“Apnapan is not the opposite of universality. It is where universality begins”

arrives without explanation. Sorrow does not need cultural footnotes. The people on screen are recognisable as kin, neighbours, rivals, elders, lovers, fools and witnesses. Regional cinema allows people to recognise themselves without translation.

But in Anuj's imagination, belonging is not a border. He believes a time will come when these boundaries will cease; when people will watch cinema from everywhere, regardless of the language belt it comes from.

A film must first belong somewhere before it can travel anywhere. 'Apnapan' is not the opposite of universality. It is where universality begins.

Darshim Saxena is a screenwriter and film analyst. She is the founder and host of 'The Second Seat', a conversation space for creators and audiences dedicated to cinema beyond box office narratives